ʿIrfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers

Based on a lecture series by
Sheikh M. S. Bahmanpour

Edited by
Zafar Abbas Juma

An invitation

وَأَنِرْ أَبْصَارَ قُلُوبِنَا بِضِيَاءِ نَظَرِهَا إِلَيْكَ حَتَّىٰ تَخْرِقَ أَبْصَارُ الْقُلُوبِ حُجُبَ النُّورِ فَتَصِلَ إِلَىٰ مَعْدِنِ الْعَظَمَةِ

Enlighten the eyes of our hearts with the light of their looking at You to the extent that they penetrate the veils of light and reach the Source of Grandeur.[1]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

What is 'irfan?

These words come from the Munajat Sha'baniyyah, a prayer many of us recite in the month of Sha'ban. The line asks God to light up the eyes of our hearts with the light of looking at Him, until those eyes pass through even the veils of light and reach the source of His grandeur. It is a request to see God with the heart and to be near Him. Requests like this one were written for us, by the Imams (as), as an endeavour for the ordinary believer.

Despite saying these words in our munajats and on auspicious occasions, we find that seeking to know God does not feature in our day-to-day routine. Praying, fasting, and paying what is due, the *wajibat*, are the dominant undertaking, and they are what most of us mean by practising the religion. The other side, the one the Munajat describes, in which the believer seeks to know God and to come near Him, is often less practised. That side of the religion is called *'irfan*.

[1] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.

ʿIrfan is the Arabic name for what English books call Islamic mysticism, and the two words do not say the same thing. "Mysticism" suggests mystery, something hidden and hard to pin down. The Arabic word names a kind of knowing. It shares its root with *maʿrifah*, knowledge, and an *ʿarif* is, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "someone who knows".

The knowing meant here is not information about God. It is knowing Him from close, with the heart, which is what the Munajat asks for. In Murtada Mutahhari's words, the ʿarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[2]. ʿIrfan is that knowing, and the training of the soul that makes it possible. It is part of the Islam we already know: its sources are the teachings of the Qur'an, the Prophet ﷺ, and the Imams (as) from his Ahl al-Bayt, and the prayer at the head of this page is one of them.

This book argues that this side of the religion is worth every believer's pursuit. ʿIrfan travels through the self and never leaves the shariʿa. It is walked by a tested and ordered method. It is rooted in the teachings of the Qur'an, the Prophet ﷺ, and the Imams from his Ahl al-Bayt. And it ends not in withdrawal from the world but in return: to people, with God, and to God Himself.

Who this book is for

The argument is addressed to anyone who prays, fasts, and recites the duʿas, and who has wondered whether there is more to these acts than getting them right; whether the religion has another dimension. No knowledge of ʿirfan, of philosophy, or of Arabic is assumed. This book strives for brevity and clarity in its role as a welcoming guide to beginning the journey towards ʿirfan. Each chapter opens with a section that details some of the words you'll meet, along with an explanation, and all terms are gathered in the glossary at the end. Additional call-out sections are spread throughout with helpful context and short side notes.

[2]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.

How the book is built

The book is built in five parts. Each answers one question and depends on the one before.

Part One, *The Call* (Chapters One to Three), asks why a believer should bother. It answers that the Qur'an invites more than the minimum: not only knowing about God, but knowing Him. The goal of ʿirfan is already on our lips in our duʿas.

Part Two, *Getting Ready* (Chapters Four to Seven), describes the landscape a traveller passes through on the journey towards ʿirfan: the self. It also positions the shariʿa as the boundary that keeps the traveller safe, and the guide as the one who walks alongside them.

Part Three, *The Road* (Chapters Eight to Twelve), asks how the path is walked: through ordered stages, by repentance, discipline, and love, to the loss of the false self.

Part Four, *Fellow Travellers* (Chapters Thirteen to Fifteen), meets those who walked the road before us. It shows the road's roots in the teachings of the Qur'an, the Prophet ﷺ, and the Imams from his Ahl al-Bayt; where its travellers arrived; and how Shia ʿirfan relates to Sufism.

Part Five, *The Destination* (Chapters Sixteen and Seventeen), asks what the road is for. The friends of God return to people, with God; every soul returns to God.

Where this book comes from

This book is inspired by a lecture series on Islamic mysticism given by Sheikh M. S. Bahmanpour. The content and structure of those lectures are the core of the book. Wherever the Sheikh is quoted directly, the words are his own, from that series.

Turning spoken lectures into a book has called for some editorial adaptation. To suit a wider readership, the book also adds context and explanation to support its main arguments. It draws on a wider literature as well: the words of the Imams in Nahj al-Balagha, al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya, and the supplications of the Mafatih; then the great Shia teachers of the path, from Sayyid Haydar Amuli in the fourteenth century to modern scholars such as Mirza Jawad

Maliki Tabrizi, ʿAllama Tabataba'i, Imam Khomeini, and Ayatullah Mutahhari. Every source is given in a footnote, for readers who want to go further.

The finer questions of ʿirfan remain an ongoing conversation among our *ʿulama'*: whether a seeker needs a guide from the first step, how much solitude is wise, and how far ordinary believers can travel. Where they differ, this book presents each view with neutrality.

What you can expect

Three guiding principles frame the discussions in the chapters that follow. The first is that ʿirfan is never pursued for the sake of powers, such as reading minds or foreseeing future events. Sheikh Bahmanpour and the wider literature agree on this, as Chapter One shows.

The second is that there is no separate sect or order through which ʿirfan must be gained. Shia ʿirfan has no institution of authority beside the Imam. How this position differs from that of the Sufi orders is explored in Chapter Fifteen.

The third principle is the most important: no part of the journey towards ʿirfan requires stepping outside the shariʿa, and nothing on that journey is gained by doing so. The beginning of ʿirfan, as the Sheikh puts it, is the shariʿa. The inner path does not go around the law or rise above it; it is the law lived from the inside. Nothing in this book asks a reader to set aside the rulings of the jurists or the guidance of their marjaʿ. A fear that mysticism might do exactly that is one reason some scholars have been wary of ʿirfan. Chapter Fourteen sets out their wider concerns, with the answers given to them.

By the end, a reader should feel able to say what ʿirfan is and is not, why it belongs to us, and what the stages and dangers of the path entail. For those who wish to go further, each chapter and the epilogue offer small, practical steps for bringing this into daily life alongside the wajibat.

PART ONE

The Call

Why travel?

The Qur’an invites more than the minimum: not only knowing about God, but knowing Him. That knowing is reached by purifying the heart, and our own prayers already ask for it.

1 · More than the minimum
2 · Knowing about God is not knowing Him
3 · You already know these words

إِلٰهِي لَمْ يَكُنْ لِي حَوْلٌ فَأَنْتَقِلَ بِهِ عَنْ مَعْصِيَتِكَ إِلاَّ فِي وَقْتٍ أَيْقَظْتَنِي لِمَحَبَّتِكَ

My Lord, I was not strong enough to move away from Your disobedience, except when You awakened me to Your love.

Munajat Sha‘baniyyah

1

More than the minimum

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ ﴿٢١﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who reflect.

Qur'an 30:21

At many weddings, someone recites a verse most of us know. In Surah al-Rum, God says that He created spouses for us from among ourselves "that you may take comfort in them", and that He ordained "affection and mercy" between husband and wife (Q 30:21). The verse ends with the words above: this is a sign for a people who reflect. Whether a person sees it depends on something in the person doing the looking. That something, and why it is worth seeking more than the minimum, is what this chapter sets out.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *'Irfan*: knowing God from close · *ma'rifah*: knowledge of God · *'arif* (plural *'urafa'*): one who knows God · *muqarrabun*: those brought near to God · *awliya' Allah*: the friends of God · *shirk*: setting up a partner beside God

What the minimum leaves out

Let's start with two claims. The first is that a believer who prays, fasts, pays what is due, and goes on hajj can hope for *jannah*, provided they do what

is *wajib* and avoid what is forbidden. This claim is not contested. Sheikh Bahmanpour accepts it as fair for ordinary believers. Mohammad Ali Shomali makes the same point, describing the obligatory rules of fiqh as “the minimally necessary conditions of human perfection”[3].

STORY: WHAT WAS ENOUGH FOR JANNAH

Someone once came to the Prophet ﷺ and said that they had no eagerness for the night prayer (*salat al-layl*), the recommended fasts, and the like. They asked whether they would go to jannah if they prayed the five daily prayers, fasted in Ramadan, paid their zakat, and went on hajj once. The Prophet said yes. Sheikh Bahmanpour opens his first lecture with this story and draws his question from the Prophet’s answer: if the obligatory acts are enough for jannah, why take on the hard work of ‘irfan?

The second claim goes further, and it is the one this book disputes. Some jurists and activists hold that the obligatory acts are the whole of the religion, and that anything beyond them is made up by the whims and wishes of certain mystics.

To see why there is more than the obligations, let’s turn to the Qur’an and read on from the verse this chapter began with. Surah al-Rum names three more sets of signs: the creation of the heavens and the earth, with the variety of our languages and colours; our sleep and our work; and the lightning and the rain that revives the dead earth (Q 30:22–24). Each verse ends as the first did, by saying who the sign is for.

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّلْعَالِمِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾

There are indeed signs in that for those who know.

Qur’an 30:22

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٢٣﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who listen.

Qur’an 30:23

[3]Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 17.

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَٰتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٢٤﴾

There are indeed signs in that for people who exercise their reason.

Qur'an 30:24

Four times in a row, the Qur'an makes the same point. The signs are all around us: in marriage, in the people we meet, in sleep, in work, and in the weather. Yet they are for those who reflect, know, listen, and reason. This reflecting, knowing, listening, and reasoning is what the Qur'an asks of us beyond the minimum.

For the avoidance of doubt, this invitation from the Qur'an is not an invitation to circumvent the law or to abandon the prescribed wajibat. Imam Khomeini insists that a genuine seeker's devotion "is within the bounds of the Shari'ah"[4]. Within those bounds, the Qur'an is just as insistent: it invites us to more than the obligatory acts.

Signs most people miss

An invitation addressed to those who reflect, know, listen, and reason implies that many people do none of these things. This is not limited to the careless. Most pious people, even those careful about the shari'a, do not find a sign in these verses. Looking at the variety of languages and colours, we are more likely to see a reason for division than a sign of God.

We have heard these verses many times, and we accept that there are signs in them because the Qur'an says so; yet accepting that a sign exists is not the same as perceiving it. The Qur'an describes the gap in one verse.

وَكَأَيِّن مِّنْ ءَايَةٍ فِي ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ يَمُرُّونَ عَلَيْهَا وَهُمْ عَنْهَا مُعْرِضُونَ ﴿١٠٥﴾

How many a sign there is in the heavens and the earth that they pass by while they are disregardful of it!

Qur'an 12:105

'Allama Tabataba'i explains what passing by a sign means; a person who sees a red light thinks of the danger it warns of, not of the colour and shape of the

[4]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

lamp. In the same way, the things of the world are signs, and "what the signs indicate is not this world, but the person of its Creator"[5]. Most of us see only the lamp. We witness the rain as rain and the marriage as a marriage, and we pass them by without perceiving what they say about their Creator.

The fault is in the receiver

If the signs are present and plain, and yet we still pass them by, the fault is on our side. The Qur'an says where it lies, speaking of people who have every faculty and use none of them.

لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ لَّا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَّا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ ءَاذَانٌ لَّا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَآ
أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ كَٱلْأَنْعَٰمِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ

they have hearts with which they do not understand, they have eyes with which they do not see, they have ears with which they do not hear. They are like cattle; indeed, they are more astray.

Qur'an 7:179

Cattle see and hear perfectly well, so the comparison cannot be about the senses. It is about what lies behind the senses. Eyes and ears take in the surface of things, whereas inside a human being there should be something more: a faculty, which animals lack, that turns what the senses take in into understanding. In most of us, it is not working.

Sheikh Bahmanpour compares this faculty to a machine. The ear catches the sound, but "there is something inside which doesn't catch it. There is a machine inside which is [rusted]." That machine is the soul. It has to be repaired before it can catch the signals of God. This is the whole subject in one sentence: mysticism is about making the soul hear, see, and reflect. It is not easy, and it requires a great deal of training.

Placing the fault in the receiver has two consequences. The first is that the problem is not a shortage of evidence. God is not withholding signs; we are failing to receive them.

[5]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 6–7.

The second is that the problem can be solved. A faculty that exists but has rusted can be repaired; one that is absent cannot be made fit for purpose. The *Kernel of the Kernels*, a record of ʿAllama Tabataba'i's early lectures on the path, opens by saying that the pull towards the unseen is "part of the innate instincts of the human being"[6]. The longing for God, and the faculty that perceives Him, are part of how we are made.

Repair is only the start. Once the inner faculty begins to work, a journey begins that, in the Sheikh's words, "has a beginning and no end".

Some do see

If the faculty can be repaired, there should be people in whom it already works. The Qur'an describes them in four ways. People can be divided into two groups: those whose souls work, and those whose souls do not. The first group are the *ʿurafa'*, the plural of *ʿarif*. The prophets and the Imams (as) are a class of their own; the ʿurafa' are ordinary believers who see more than the rest. The first description of them is in Surah al-Anfal.

إِنَّمَا ٱلْمُؤْمِنُونَ ٱلَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ ٱللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ

The faithful are only those whose hearts tremble [with awe] when Allah is mentioned,

Qur'an 8:2

A heart trembles only at the mention of someone it has some experience of; a name means little to a person who does not know whom it names. The believers of this verse are thus the believers who know Allah. A verse in Surah Al ʿImran goes further, giving them another name.

شَهِدَ ٱللَّهُ أَنَّهُۥ لَآ إِلَٰهَ إِلَّا هُوَ وَٱلْمَلَٰٓئِكَةُ وَأُو۟لُوا۟ ٱلْعِلْمِ

Allah ... bears witness that there is no god except Him, and [so do] the angels and those who possess knowledge.

Qur'an 3:18

[6] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 4.

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads “those who possess knowledge” as another name for the ‘urafa’. Every Muslim knows that there is no god but Allah. Our knowledge of *tawhid*, God’s oneness, is still not the knowledge of those who witness it. Tawhid is simple to say and hard to grasp; the intellect alone cannot reach its depths, and only the awakened soul can. Surah Fatir describes the same people by what they feel.

إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى ٱللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ ٱلْعُلَمَٰٓؤُا۟

Only those of Allah’s servants having knowledge fear Him.

Qur’an 35:28

Most of us fear Allah’s punishment. The people of this verse fear Him with a fear that is not about punishment at all.

Surah Yunus gives them another name: the *awliya’ Allah*, the friends of God (Q 10:62). Imam ‘Ali (as) describes what these friends see that others miss.

God’s special devotees are those who perceive the world’s reality when others are deceived by her appearance. They occupy themselves with what is coming when others occupy themselves with the present.[7]

Nahj al-Balagha

Other people look at the surface of the world; the friends of God look at what lies inside it. This does not mean turning away from the world. There is nothing wrong with pursuing material wealth in this life; the trouble is being solely occupied with it. The friends of God have families, friends, and a place in society, as we do. They think not about themselves but about God, and in their hearts they are cut off from everything else.

What they are given, and why it is open to all

The Qur’an names three things these people receive. The first is nearness: Surah al-Waqi‘a sorts people on the Last Day, and at the top it places the Foremost Ones.

[7] Imam ‘Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.403.

وَٱلسَّٰبِقُونَ ٱلسَّٰبِقُونَ ﴿١٠﴾ أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ ٱلْمُقَرَّبُونَ ﴿١١﴾

And the Foremost Ones are the foremost ones: they are the ones brought near [to Allah],

Qur'an 56:10-11

The Arabic for "brought near" is *muqarrabun*. God is not far from anyone. Being brought near means that a veil between the person and God has been removed, so that they understand far more.

The second gift is a different kind of life, promised in Surah al-Nahl to whoever acts righteously, man or woman, while having faith.

مَنْ عَمِلَ صَٰلِحًا مِّن ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنثَىٰ وَهُوَ مُؤْمِنٌ فَلَنُحْيِيَنَّهُۥ حَيَوٰةً طَيِّبَةً

Whoever acts righteously, [whether] male or female, should he be faithful, We shall revive him with a good life

Qur'an 16:97

This good life (*hayat tayyiba*), the life the mystics seek, is a clean life. Its people live in the world without being soiled by it, rising above the worries that occupy everyone else.

The third gift is peace, promised in the verse of Surah Yunus that names the friends of God.

أَلَآ إِنَّ أَوْلِيَآءَ ٱللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾

Look! The friends of Allah will indeed have no fear nor will they grieve

Qur'an 10:62

For the muqarrabun, the terms are entirely different from those of ordinary believers.

None of this would matter to an ordinary reader if it were reserved for prophets. Surah al-Nisa' answers that concern.

وَمَن يُطِعِ ٱللَّهَ وَٱلرَّسُولَ فَأُوْلَٰٓئِكَ مَعَ ٱلَّذِينَ أَنعَمَ ٱللَّهُ عَلَيْهِم مِّنَ ٱلنَّبِيِّـۧنَ وَٱلصِّدِّيقِينَ وَٱلشُّهَدَآءِ وَٱلصَّٰلِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ رَفِيقًا ﴿٦٩﴾

Whoever obeys Allah and the Apostle—they are with those whom Allah has blessed, including the prophets and the truthful, the martyrs and the righteous, and excellent companions are they!

Qur’an 4:69

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads this verse as naming four ranks of those God has blessed: the prophets; the truthful (*siddiqin*); the *shuhada’*, which the translation used here renders “martyrs” and which he takes as “the witnesses”; and the righteous (*salihin*). The first three ranks are beyond us; the fourth is a doorway. The salihin are those able to receive this favour, and from among them God chooses the truthful and the prophets. The way in is righteous action, as the verse on the good life also says.

That doorway is open to people like us. It is difficult, but we are made for it. We call ourselves human beings, yet, in the Sheikh’s words, “we are not yet human beings”: we begin with the capacity to become human in the full sense that the prophets are, and God wants us to reach it.

This is the case for pursuing ‘irfan. The Qur’an invites more than the minimum, and what stands in the way is a faculty in us that can be repaired. On the other side of that repair lie nearness to God, a good life, and freedom from fear and grief. That rank is open to any believer who obeys God and the Prophet and acts righteously.

The aim is God, not powers

Pursuing ‘irfan means training the soul, and soul-training is not unique to Islam. People take up the inner life for different reasons. Some train the soul in an attempt to gain power: to be in two places at once, to see the future or the past, or to master the hidden world of the soul. This kind of mysticism must be held apart from ‘irfan. Islamic mysticism is about catching the signs of Allah: becoming sensitive to them, and learning to hear and see.

Sheikh Bahmanpour ends his first lecture more strongly. ‘Irfan, he says, is not about gaining power over the soul to work the wonders of the saints

(*karamat*) or the miracles of the prophets (*mu'jizat*). Such powers are *shirk*: the sin of setting up a partner beside God.

The great teachers of the Shia tradition make closely related points, each in his own words. 'Allama Tabataba'i tells the traveller that he "has no right to seek occult experiences and miraculous qualities", nor to perform austerities or recite invocations to gain powers such as crossing great distances in a moment or reading the thoughts of others. Whoever does so "does not move on the path of the Beloved's pleasure and his worship is not for the sake of God". It is his own self that he worships, "though he may not admit it by word of mouth"[8].

> **WHO'S WHO: 'ALLAMA TABATABA'I**
>
> Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Tabataba'i is best known as the author of *al-Mizan*, a commentary on the Qur'an in twenty volumes[9]. His student Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Husayni Tihrani describes him as having flown "with the two wings of knowledge and action". He travelled the path in both philosophy and gnosis under the guidance of the gnostic Mirza 'Ali Aqa Qadi, and after years of philosophical argument he "came to settle down at the sacred threshold of the Qur'an"[10]. *Kernel of the Kernels* (*Lubb al-Lubab*) is Tihrani's record of the lectures on ethics and gnosis that Tabataba'i gave to students in Qum in 1949–50[11]. He also wrote the preface to *Light Within Me*[12], from which several quotations in this chapter come.

Imam Khomeini reports the test his teacher Ayatullah Shahabadi used: the measure of true spiritual effort is how much selfishness is in it. If a traveller's "spiritual exercises are meant for acquiring powers for worldly ends, his efforts are rendered invalid"[13].

Murtada Mutahhari uses the same word as Sheikh Bahmanpour. The 'urafa', he writes, consider it "a kind of shirk (polytheism) for one's goal in life and particularly in worship to be something other than God Himself", and he

[8] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 28–29.
[9] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 30.
[10] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 8.
[11] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 9.
[12] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.
[13] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

recalls Imam ʿAli (as) saying that he worshipped God not from fear of His Fire or desire for His Paradise but because he found Him worthy of worship[14].

The scholars differ in emphasis but agree that powers are not the aim. Mutahhari also explains why seeking them would be shirk: the goal has become something other than God.

Seeking, and nothing else

With powers set aside, what remains is the definition Sheikh Bahmanpour gives at the end of his first lecture: ʿirfan "is actually seeking and nothing else". It seeks the knowledge of God (*maʿrifah*) and the love of God (*mahabba*).

> ع **WORD STUDY: ʿIRFAN AND MAʿRIFAH**
>
> *ʿIrfan*, *maʿrifah*, *ʿarif* and its plural *ʿurafa'* belong to one family of words about knowing. An ʿarif, as Sheikh Bahmanpour puts it, is "someone who knows". "Mystic" is used of Christians, Hindus, and Buddhists alike; ʿarif is the Islamic word, and it makes a precise claim. Murtada Mutahhari draws the line. The philosopher wants a correct picture of the world in his mind. The ʿarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[15]. *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (as), says that there is no way to God except through knowledge[16]. What kind of knowledge that is, and how it differs from what we learn from books, is the subject of Chapter Two.

ʿIrfan is therefore worth pursuing: it is the training of the soul to perceive and love God, open to every believer, and sought for God alone.

If the aim is to know and love God, what kind of knowing is that?

> ➤ **TRY THIS**
>
> Sheikh Bahmanpour builds his first lesson on the four signs of Surah al-Rum. For one week, read Q 30:21–24 slowly once a day. After each verse, ask yourself what he found in its ending: whether you reflect, whether you know, whether you listen, and whether you use your reason. Then, at some point in the day, notice one of the four signs where it occurs in your life: the affection in your

[14] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 44.
[15] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.
[16] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 9.

> home, the languages and colours of the people you meet, your own sleep and the work that earns your living, or the rain.

2

Knowing about God is not knowing Him

On a day of fasting in Ramadan, by late afternoon, no one has to be told that they are hungry. They do not read it in a book or work it out from the clock. The hunger is known from the inside. Sheikh Bahmanpour uses hunger to describe a kind of knowing that study cannot give.

Most of what we know of God is of the kind gained by study. We learn the rulings of fiqh, the beliefs the scholars set out, and the history of the Prophet ﷺ and the Imams (as). All of it is knowledge about God. The Qur'an's invitation to more than the minimum is an invitation to know and love God. That knowing is like the fasting person's knowledge of hunger. It is knowing God directly, not only knowing about Him. This chapter sets out why knowing about God is not knowing Him, and how He comes to be known.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *ʿIlm*: knowledge, especially knowledge gained by study · *ʿilm al-husuli*: acquired knowledge · *ʿilm al-huduri*: knowledge by presence · *ʿaql*: the reasoning intellect · *suluk*: wayfaring; the path of purification

Knowing about, and knowing

Let's start with the two kinds of knowing. The first is acquired knowledge (*ʿilm al-husuli*). It reaches us from outside, through the senses or by reasoning.

We form concepts of the things around us and then analyse those concepts. Almost everything we learn from teachers and books is of this kind, including what we know about God.

Acquired knowledge works by defining its object. To understand a thing, we sort it into a category and mark where it ends and something else begins. The Arabic word for a definition (*hadd*) also means a limit: to define a thing is to limit it. The old definition of a human being as "the rational animal" works by drawing a line round us.

The second kind is knowledge by presence (*'ilm al-huduri*). It does not come from outside and needs no concept to carry it; it is with the soul already. The plainest case is our knowledge of our own self. Hunger is another, and so are pain and anxiety. Anxiety has a cause outside us, yet the feeling itself arises inside the soul.

Knowledge by presence is complete. When the body is hungry, the soul knows it at once and without effort, and nothing of the hunger is missed. The hunger may even be false, and yet what is felt is real. A person may be wrong to think that their body needs food. They cannot be wrong that they feel hungry.

Knowledge by presence is what the mystics are after. Sheikh Bahmanpour defines mysticism as the urge to reach out to the infinite through knowledge by presence. The two kinds of knowing aim at different things: acquired knowledge (*'ilm*) aims at understanding, and knowledge by presence (*ma'rifah*) aims at arriving. A person does not try to understand their hunger; they arrive at it and feel it. In the same way, the mystic's aim is to arrive at God, not to define Him. A definition draws a limit, and God has none.

Imam Khomeini records a view that draws the same line between two kinds of people. On this view, a gnostic of God (an 'arif) "knows God through direct witnessing", while a scholar of God "attains the knowledge of God through philosophical proofs"[17]. The gnostic's witnessing is knowledge by presence, and the scholar's proofs are acquired knowledge.

ع WORD STUDY: 'ILM AL-HUSULI AND 'ILM AL-HUDURI

[17] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 542.

Husul means acquiring or obtaining, whereas *hudur* means presence. In acquired knowledge (*ʻilm al-husuli*), what reaches the mind is a concept or an image of the thing, while the thing itself stays outside. In knowledge by presence (*ʻilm al-huduri*), the thing known is itself present to the soul, as our own self, our hunger, and our pain are present. The phrase Imam Khomeini uses for the gnostic's witnessing, *mushahada huduriyya* (witnessing by presence), comes from the same root. Sheikh Bahmanpour notes that the religious texts use *ʻilm* and *maʻrifah* for the same thing, whereas Imam Khomeini writes of "an evident difference" between *ʻirfan* and *ʻilm*[18]. This book keeps the two apart to make the two kinds of knowing easier to see. Chapter One's Word Study noted that there is no way to God except through knowledge, and left open what type of knowledge it refers to. If *maʻrifah* is arriving, as this chapter describes it, that knowledge is knowledge by presence.

Where reason stops

Acquired knowledge is the work of reason (*ʻaql*), the faculty by which we understand and argue. Reason has a limit. When we know a thing, we know its attributes: its colour, its size, and what it does. Every description says that it is brown, square, or useful, and none says what the "it" is. Ibn Sina, the master of philosophy, granted this. The reality of things, he held, is beyond the reach of human reason.

If reason cannot reach what the things around us are, it falls still further short of God. God has no colour or size for the mind to take hold of. Imam ʻAli (as) speaks to this at the opening of the first oration in *Nahj al-Balagha*, where he praises God.

لا يدركه بعد الهمم ولا يناله غوص الفطن

Soaring thoughts cannot reach him and deep minds cannot fathom him.[19]

Nahj al-Balagha

The two images can be read as reason at its widest range and reason at its deepest, and Imam ʻAli says that neither reaches God. The next sentence of the oration continues: God "cannot be described, for he is beyond the limits

[18]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 542.
[19]Imam ʻAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.1.1.

of demarcated boundaries"[20]. A definition draws a line round its object, and there is no line to draw round God.

Reason still has work it can do. It can argue that God exists, and it can say what He is not: God cannot be an object, and He is not in one place and absent from another. All of this is knowledge about God. Apart from the proof that He exists, the rest is negative knowledge, in which each statement says what God is not, rather than saying what He is.

'Irfan asks for the positive side. We cannot know God's essence. What 'irfan seeks is His attributes, known positively: God as the Merciful, the Compassionate, and the Forgiving. The names can be learned from a book. To know God as Merciful from within, as a hungry person knows their hunger, is knowledge by presence. Mulla Sadra held that knowledge by presence is the only way to know the reality of anything, and the only way to know God. The comparison with hunger shows how this knowledge is had, not how much is known. It has degrees, and in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "the more you know, the more bewildered you will become".

We have knowledge by presence only of what is within us: our own self and some of its states. A sense of God already lives there, however faint: a vague idea of God that we carry inside us. If God is to be known, and not only known about, the knowing must happen within the soul.

◈ WHO'S WHO: MULLA SADRA AND THE SCHOOLS OF PHILOSOPHY

Mulla Sadra died in 1050/1640[21]. In Sheikh Bahmanpour's account, Islamic philosophy before him had two branches: the Peripatetic (*al-hikma al-mashsha'iyya*) and the Illuminationist. Mulla Sadra changed its course. He called his own philosophy neither of these but the transcendent philosophy (*al-hikma al-muta'aliya*). He claimed for it a rationalised mysticism, giving rational argument to what the mystics know only by experience. Murtada Mutahhari contrasts the means of the philosopher and of the 'arif. The philosopher works with "reason, deductions and proofs", whereas the 'arif works with "the heart and the purification, disciplining and perfecting of the self"[22]. Mulla Sadra studied the 'irfan of Ibn 'Arabi deeply without belonging to any Sufi order, and rated

[20] Imam 'Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.1.1.
[21] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 40.
[22] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.
[23] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 35, 40.

Ibn ‘Arabi above Ibn Sina[23]. *Kernel of the Kernels* records that after a lifetime in philosophy he became absorbed in worship and the purification of his inner being. He asked God’s pardon for the part of his life spent studying “the opinions of the pseudo-philosophers and polemicists from among the theologians”, until “it became clear to me that their syllogisms were barren and their path devoid of straightness”[24].

Light in the heart

A knowledge that analysis cannot produce must be given. A hadith that Imam Khomeini quotes in his *Forty Hadith* says who gives it.

> *Knowledge is not extensive learning. Rather, it is a light that God casts in the heart of whomever He wills.*[25]
>
> Hadith

The hadith sets the two kinds of knowing side by side. Extensive learning is acquired knowledge, gathered from outside, whereas the light is not gathered at all: God places it in the heart.

The words “whomever He wills” can be read as saying that God chooses some hearts for His light and passes over others. Sheikh Bahmanpour speaks of the light through a verse of Surah al-Nur.

ٱللَّهُ نُورُ ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ ۚ

> *Allah is the Light of the heavens and the earth.*
>
> Qur’an 24:35

Allah’s light is everywhere, in the heavens and in the earth, and He is with us wherever we are. In the Sheikh’s account, nothing is held back on God’s side, and He does not pick out some hearts to light and pass over others. The same verse goes on, “Allah guides to His Light whomever He wishes”, and the lectures also say that God chooses those He loves. God holds back His light from no heart, so what keeps a heart dark is that it is closed. Those He

[24] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 7.
[25] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.

chooses are those He loves, and the traveller opens the heart in the hope of being among them.

Opening the heart is purifying it, and Imam Khomeini explains what follows once that is done. When the soul is purified, he writes, divine teaching follows, "for there is no niggardliness in the higher realms, which are bounteous by necessity"[26]. The teaching remains God's gift, and the purified heart waits for it. Imam Khomeini grounds this in a verse of Surah al-Baqarah that links God's teaching to wariness of Him.

وَٱتَّقُواْ ٱللَّهَ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمُ ٱللَّهُ

Be wary of Allah and Allah will teach you.

Qur'an 2:282

In the verse, God's teaching follows on from wariness of Him. In the same way, the light comes to the hearts of the pure, and darkness covers the impure.

Knowledge of God is therefore a light given to a purified heart, not something gathered by study. A knowledge given to the heart also travels differently. The knowledge of books passes from mind to mouth, through language, whereas the knowledge of the 'urafa' passes "from heart to heart", in the Sheikh's words. Receiving it directly from God is possible but difficult, and one usually has to start through someone else. Chapter Seven describes the guide.

STORY: A THOUSAND DOORS OF KNOWLEDGE

We know how knowledge passes from one mind to another, and Sheikh Bahmanpour traces the route. The speaker has an image in mind, and the body turns it into speech. The speech travels through the listener's nervous system and raises an image in the listener's mind. Of knowledge passing from one heart to another we have no such experience. He then recalls a report from Imam 'Ali (as): when the Prophet ﷺ was on his deathbed, a thousand doors of knowledge opened to Imam 'Ali's heart, and from each door a thousand more. In the Sheikh's telling, this knowledge did not come through language. It passed from heart to heart, and it is the kind of knowledge the 'urafa' have.

[26]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.

The path is purification

If the light is everywhere and the heart is closed, the path to knowing God is the opening of the heart. Two Arabic words mark the difference between this path and study. Knowledge learned at a university or a seminary comes through thought (*fikr*): we think, put things together, analyse, and find out. Knowledge of God comes through wayfaring (*suluk*), the path to purity.

Wayfaring has two parts, and the Sheikh names both: "You purify yourself and then wait for Allah to put the light in your heart." The light is not absent while the heart waits. The waiting is the patience of a heart that has done its part and leaves the rest to God. The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah ties the light to the path in one line.

إِنَّ مَنِ ٱنْتَهَجَ بِكَ لَمُسْتَنِيرٌ

One who follows Your path is enlightened.[27]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The same prayer asks, in the line this book opened with, for the eyes of the heart to be lit until they reach the source of God's grandeur. This line says who receives that light: the one who follows God's path.

Following that path begins with the shariʿa. Its first step is to polish the soul by doing whatever the Prophet ﷺ has asked. Without this there is no maʿrifah. The Qur'an calls the believers to answer Allah and the Apostle when he summons them to what will give them life (Q 8:24). That life comes when a person follows the Prophet completely.

Practice depends on knowing what to practise, and this is where study comes in. ʿAllama Tabataba'i, in the lectures recorded in *Kernel of the Kernels*, gives study an early place. Once the traveller has set out with a sincere intention, the first essential, he says, is knowledge of the rules of the shariʿa, learned from a jurist. The traveller puts that knowledge into practice and persists until conviction and gnosis (*maʿrifah*) grow by degrees, "for knowledge gives birth to action and action in turn brings knowledge"[28].

[27] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §88.

[28] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 56.

Imam Khomeini gives learning its place, with a warning. A learning that does not bring faith with it, he writes, "is the greatest of veils", yet "one has to approach a veil in order to tear it into shreds". He adds that the sciences are "seeds of (spiritual) experience". He allows that high stations can be reached without them, but calls this unusual[29]. Without the polishing of the soul, in the Sheikh's words, there is no maʿrifah. Study can serve purification, but it cannot replace it.

STORY: THE PHILOSOPHER AND THE ʿARIF

Murtada Mutahhari records a meeting between Ibn Sina and Abu Saʿid ibn Abi al-Khayr, one of the most famous of all the ʿurafa'. Abu Saʿid was preaching on the necessity of deeds, and on obedience and disobedience to God. Ibn Sina answered him with a quatrain (a poem of four lines). Wherever God's favour and grace are found, it ran, "Let the not-done be like the done, the done like the not-done." The verse leaned on God's forgiveness in place of deeds. Abu Saʿid replied at once with a quatrain of his own, which ends: "Do not rely on forgiveness, for never / Was the not-done like the done, the done like the not-done"[30]. In Sheikh Bahmanpour's account, Ibn Sina later wrote to Abu Saʿid asking to learn from him. Mutahhari, who calls Ibn Sina "mainly a philosopher, not a mystic", notes that "especially towards the end of his life he developed mystic inclinations"[31].

Knowing by drawing near

What study cannot give comes to the 'urafa' through purification. They are brought near to God and know Him by presence: a veil is removed, rather than a definition learned. Their knowing is present to the soul, as hunger is present to the one who fasts. It comes as a light that God gives to a purified heart, and so it differs in kind from knowing about God.

Where, then, does an ordinary believer already stand on this path?

➤ TRY THIS

In prostration in the daily prayer, many of us say, "Glory belongs to my Lord, the Exalted, and Him do I praise." 'Allama Tabataba'i uses these words to show how

[29] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 403.
[30] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 29.
[31] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.

knowledge follows action[32]. For one week, in one prayer each day, say them slowly, “believing it to be a fact”. Notice your own lowliness with your forehead on the ground, then the majesty of the One you are calling exalted. From “a very minor action, such as this dhikr said in prostration”, he says, a person comes to discover God’s absolute majesty[33].

[32] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 56–57.

[33] ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 56–57.

3

You already know these words

وَّقَلْبِي بِحُبِّكَ مُتَيَّماً

And my heart enthralled by Your love![34]

Duʿa Kumayl

These words come near the end of Duʿa Kumayl, the prayer Imam ʿAli (as) taught to Kumayl ibn Ziyad, one of his close disciples. Many of us hear it on Thursday evenings, as the Mafatih recommends[35]. The line asks God for a heart enthralled by His love.

A heart enthralled by God's love is one of the two things ʿirfan seeks. Other prayers we recite ask for the second, knowing God. This chapter shows that we already know these words.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *duʿa*: supplication, any request made to God · *munajat*: an intimate, whispered prayer to God · *Mafatih al-Jinan*: the standard manual of Shia prayers[36] · *inqitaʿ*: severance of the heart from all but God

[34] *Duʿa Kumayl* (duas.org), §221.
[35] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 129.
[36] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 112.

Cut off from all else

The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah asks to be cut off from everything before it asks to see God. This book opened on its request for light in the eyes of the heart. In the prayer, that line follows straight on from a request for severance. The order fits what Sheikh Bahmanpour says of those who seek God: they want to know Him and to look at Him, but "they have to cut off from everything first".

إِلٰهِي هَبْ لِي كَمَالَ ٱلاِنْقِطَاعِ إِلَيْكَ

My Lord, grant me complete severance of my relations with everything else[37]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The Munajat asks for this severance (*inqitaʿ*) in full. Taken at its word, the request could sound like a call to leave family, work, and society behind. The Sheikh raises the question himself: is it good to cut off from everything else completely? His answer is "in the heart yes". Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali, recited on the nights of Ramadan, names what is to be cut away from the heart.

سَيِّدِي أَخْرِجْ حُبَّ ٱلدُّنْيَا مِنْ قَلْبِي

O my Master, (please) expel love for the world out of my heart[38]

Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali

The prayer asks that love of the world leave the heart. Duʿa ʿArafah, as given in the Mafatih, describes the same severance from God's side: He has already made it in the hearts of those He loves.

[37] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §104.

[38] *Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §384.

وَأَنْتَ ٱلَّذِي أَزَلْتَ ٱلأَغْيَارَ عَنْ قُلُوبِ أَحِبَّائِكَ حَتَّىٰ لَمْ يُحِبُّوا سِوَاكَ

It is You Who have removed love for others from the hearts of Your lovers so that they have loved none save You[39]

Duʿa ʿArafah

Both prayers speak of love, and both remove it from the heart. The severance the prayers ask for is therefore in the heart.

To see, to love, to draw near

A heart cleared of everything but God is free for Him. The prayers go on to ask for three things: to see God with the heart, to love Him, and to come near Him.

The first is sight. The Munajat asks God to light the eyes of the heart so that they look at Him and pass even through the veils of light. Yet the Qur'an says that sight cannot perceive God (Q 6:103). The difficulty is a real one, and people unfamiliar with the mystics' wording sometimes call such lines a mistake.

The prayer does not ask for the eyes in our heads. It asks for the eyes of the heart. Our physical eyes work perfectly well, and still we miss God's signs, because the inner faculty behind them is blind. The prayer asks God to light that faculty. It is the light the last chapter described, which God gives to a purified heart. Duʿa ʿArafah says He has already lit that light in the hearts of His intimate servants, the friends of God (*awliya'*).

أَنْتَ ٱلَّذِي أَشْرَقْتَ ٱلأَنْوَارَ فِي قُلُوبِ أَوْلِيَائِكَ

It is You Who have lit the illuminations in the hearts of Your intimate servants[40]

Duʿa ʿArafah

STORY: THE COMPANION WHO SAW PARADISE

[39] Imam al-Husayn, *Duʿa ʿArafah* (duas.org), §783–784.
[40] Imam al-Husayn, *Duʿa ʿArafah* (duas.org), §781.

The Prophet ﷺ once asked one of his companions how he was. The companion answered that he could see people's places in paradise, and the Prophet accepted what he said. Sheikh Bahmanpour tells this to show that the companion was not set apart from the others. He had purified his soul, and anyone who goes through that purification can see what others cannot. A version in al-Kafi, quoted by Murtada Mutahhari, names him Harithah ibn Malik al-Ansari, a young man. In it the Prophet turns to his companions and says, "This is a man whose heart has been illuminated with the light of faith by God"[41]. It is the light Duʿa ʿArafah says God has lit in the hearts of His friends.

The second request is love. The Munajat asks for a place among God's friends, and it defines that place by love.

إِلٰهِي أَقِمْنِي فِي أَهْلِ وِلايَتِكَ مُقَامَ مَنْ رَجَا ٱلزِّيَادَةَ مِنْ مَحَبَّتِكَ

My Lord, place me among Your friends in the position of one who hopes for an increase in Your love.[42]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The Sheikh reads the friendship asked for here (*wilaya*) as having two parts. One is maʿrifah: understanding God, looking at Him, and knowing Him. The other is love for Him. The love never stops, and the knowing keeps growing. These are the two things ʿirfan seeks, and both are in one line of the Munajat.

The third request is nearness, and the Munajat makes it earlier in the same prayer.

إِلٰهِي هَبْ لِي قَلْباً يُدْنِيهِ مِنْكَ شَوْقُهُ

My Lord, provide me with a heart, the passion of which may bring it near You[43]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

[41]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 19.

[42]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §92–93.

[43]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §82.

The request is for a heart whose own passion brings it near, and that heart is itself asked of God. The Whispered Prayer of the Lovers is one of fifteen whispered prayers printed with al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya. It asks for a place among those God has chosen for His nearness.

> *My God, place us with him whom Thou hast chosen for Thy nearness and Thy friendship, ... granted gazing upon Thy face*[44]
>
> Whispered Prayer of the Lovers

The difference nearness makes is felt in prayer. For some of us, calling on God can feel like calling into the sky from far away. Others feel Him present when they call, and feel His response. With this third request, the prayers have asked for all that ʿirfan seeks: to see God with the heart, to love Him, and to be near Him.

A pupil reading above his level

Requests this high raise a difficulty, which Sheikh Bahmanpour puts plainly. These words come from the peak of understanding and longing, from those brought near to God, yet ordinary believers are told to recite them. He compares it to telling a primary school boy to read university books.

Part of the answer is in the prayers themselves, which speak from need. Duʿa ʿArafah comes to God with nothing to offer but its need of Him.

> هَا أَنَا أَتَوَسَّلُ إِلَيْكَ بِفَقْرِي إِلَيْكَ
>
> *Here I am begging You by my need for You.*[45]
>
> Duʿa ʿArafah

Need is the only plea in this line, and the Munajat line at the head of Part One goes further. There the reciter admits to having had no strength to move away from disobedience "except when You awakened me to Your love"[46], so even the turning towards God is His doing.

[44] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 656.
[45] Imam al-Husayn, *Duʿa ʿArafah* (duas.org), §689.
[46] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 164.

The Sheikh's answer to the difficulty is that we have been honoured to be allowed to recite these words, though they are not of our level. The prayers' own pleas from need fit that answer. They claim no level, so a reciter may say them without understanding many of their meanings. If the reciter is sincere, God may grant the request, and what the Imams wanted, He granted them.

> ع **WORD STUDY: DUʿA AND MUNAJAT**
> *Duʿa* is the general word for supplication: any request addressed to God, in any words. A *munajat* is a duʿa spoken as a private conversation with God. The Mafatih's English calls the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah a "confidential prayer"[47], and William Chittick translates the fifteen munajat printed with the Sahifa as "whispered prayers"[48]. Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi suggests why the Imams' supplications reach further than their other words. In their narrations, he writes, they spoke with people, whereas in their supplications they spoke with God, and the level of speech depends on the understanding of the one addressed. The Qur'an, in his terms, is a "Descending-Qur'an", God's words to His servants. The supplications are an "Ascending-Qur'an", the words of His most distinguished servants rising towards Him[49].

Prayers for ordinary nights

The invitation to recite these words reaches us through a book most believers already own. Four of the prayers quoted in this chapter are in the Mafatih al-Jinan, which sets each of them on a night or a day in the believer's year.

The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah is listed among the acts of the month of Shaʿban. The Mafatih reports it as the prayer Imam ʿAli (as) and the other Imams used to say in that month[50]. It adds that it is "advisable to say it with presence of heart all the time"[51]. The full text, in Arabic and English, is given in the Appendix.

The other prayers have their own times. Duʿa Kumayl belongs to Thursday evenings and to the night of mid-Shaʿban[52]. Duʿa ʿArafah is the prayer of Imam

[47] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 243.
[48] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 9.
[49] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 43.
[50] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 243.
[51] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 245.
[52] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 129.

al-Husayn (as) on the Day of ʿArafah[53]. Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali belongs to Ramadan, when Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin (as) said it in the last hour of each night[54]. Maliki Tabrizi tells the traveller not to forget it, and to say it every night or every other night, as his mood and situation allow[55].

Said on nights we keep, these words become familiar. Imam Khomeini could count on that familiarity. "You are already familiar with the words used in Imams' supplications," he told his listeners, before reading them lines from the Shaʿbaniyyah[56].

⧗ HISTORY: THE MAFATIH AND THE SAHIFA

The prayers in this chapter reach ordinary believers through two books. The *Mafatih al-Jinan* ("Keys to the Heavens") gathers the supplications of the Imams, the words to be recited at particular times, and the forms for visiting the Imams' shrines. Its compiler, Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, was a scholar of vast learning who died in Najaf in 1359/1940[57]. Al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya is far older. William Chittick calls it "the oldest prayer manual in Islamic sources", composed by Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin (as). Shia tradition ranks it behind only the Qur'an and Nahj al-Balagha[58]. The fourth Imam died in Medina in 95/713–4, or a year earlier[59]. The fifteen whispered prayers, the Whispered Prayer of the Lovers among them, were added to several modern editions of the Sahifa. They seem to have reached most Shia through ʿAllama Muhammad Baqir Majlisi, the compiler of *Bihar al-Anwar*[60].

Reciting the words is not the same as comprehending what they describe. Maliki Tabrizi sees the supplications as a servant's own words rising to God. That, he writes, "is not accepted and comprehended by any one, except a small number of believers who are thoroughly familiar and enlightened"[61].

Sheikh Bahmanpour still recommends the Munajat to every listener, to be recited in Shaʿban as often as they can. The two positions answer different

[53] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 374.
[54] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 282.
[55] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 111.
[56] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 156.
[57] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 112.
[58] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 7.
[59] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 8.
[60] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 9.
[61] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 43.

questions: how far a reciter reaches, and who may begin. This chapter claims only that anyone may begin these prayers, with access to their words rather than attainment of what they ask for.

Words already on our lips

Access to these words is where an ordinary believer already stands on the path. In the voice of someone in need, and on nights the ordinary believer keeps, the prayers ask for what ʿirfan seeks. The goal of ʿirfan is therefore not foreign to us: it is already on our lips. In saying these prayers, we have already begun to ask for it.

These prayers keep asking God to work on the heart, the self within us. What is this self?

> ➤ **TRY THIS**
>
> This week, read the petitions of the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah from §82 to §111 (in the Appendix) once, slowly, with the English beside the Arabic. The Mafatih advises saying the prayer "with presence of heart"[62]. As you read, notice the requests this chapter has followed: to be cut off from all else, to see, to love, and to draw near. When Shaʿban comes, follow the Sheikh's own advice and recite the whole prayer "as much as you can".

[62] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 245.

PART TWO

Getting Ready

What do I need before I set out?

The road to God runs through our own self, which is deeper than it looks. The shariʻa is its boundary from the first step to the last, and a tested guide walks beside the traveller, under the Imams (as) and never in their place.

4 · Know yourself, know your Lord
5 · The soul and its worlds
6 · No path outside the law
7 · Finding a guide

فَقَدْ هَرَبْتُ إِلَيْكَ وَوَقَفْتُ بَيْنَ يَدَيْكَ مُسْتَكِيناً
لَكَ مُتَضَرِّعاً إِلَيْكَ

I have come running to You and am standing before You imploring You in humility.

Munajat Shaʻbaniyyah

4

Know yourself, know your Lord

In the month of Shaʿban, many of us recite the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah. One of its lines is a confession.

قَدْ جُرْتُ عَلَىٰ نَفْسِي فِي ٱلنَّظَرِ لَهَا

I have been unjust to my soul for I have not looked after it.[63]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The prayer offers these words as a "confession of my sins"[64]. They also say something about the soul. It was given into our care (Q 5:105), and it can be neglected.

The soul deserves that care because everything we know, we know with it. Our eyes and ears take in the world, but the soul is what understands what they bring. In Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, the soul is "the means to understand and to learn".

[63]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 163; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §32.

[64]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 163.

We know our own soul from the inside. We know the images in our mind the same way: they are present to the soul, so we know them with nothing in between. This is knowledge by presence (*ʿilm al-huduri*). The soul's knowledge of itself is its clearest case, since here the one who perceives and the thing perceived are the same.

The theory of ʿirfan therefore begins with the soul, since every other study is carried out with it. Knowing God, rather than knowing about Him, would need this same direct knowing, and so it too must happen in the soul. This chapter sets out why we must know ourselves to know our Lord, and how.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *nafs*: the soul or self · *ruh*: the spirit; the higher soul · *liqaʾ Allah*: the meeting, or encounter, with God · *qurb*: nearness to God · *hijab* (plural *hujub*): a veil between the heart and God

The human story is the soul's story

The Qur'an shows what rests on the soul. Surah al-Shams opens with a run of oaths: by the sun and the moon, the day and the night, the sky and Him who built it, and the earth and Him who spread it (Q 91:1–6). The last oath is by the soul and "Him who fashioned it, and inspired it with [discernment between] its virtues and vices" (Q 91:7–8). Every soul comes with the means to tell good from evil, and the next two verses say what follows from that gift.

قَدْ أَفْلَحَ مَن زَكَّىٰهَا ﴿٩﴾ وَقَدْ خَابَ مَن دَسَّىٰهَا ﴿١٠﴾

one who purifies it is felicitous, and one who betrays it fails.

Qur'an 91:9-10

Success and failure, in these verses, turn on what is done with the soul. Whether a person purifies the soul or betrays it decides the outcome of their life.

The whole story of a human being in this world is therefore the story of the soul. We are here to develop it and to make of it what we choose. The Munajat's confession names the failure the surah describes, since a soul that has not been looked after is a soul that has not been purified.

◈ **WHO'S WHO: MIRZA MUHAMMAD ʿALI SHAHABADI**

Mirza Muhammad ʿAli Shahabadi was the teacher who most shaped Imam Khomeini's spiritual life. Imam Khomeini refers to him as "our shaykh" (*shaykhuna*), and the introduction to the *Forty Hadith* describes their relationship as "that of a murid with his murshid" (a disciple with his spiritual guide)[65]. Shahabadi taught a few select students the *Fusus al-Hikam* of Ibn ʿArabi[66]. For the care of the soul, however, he sent them to the Qur'an. He told them to attend constantly to the closing verses of Surah al-Hashr, which begin by telling every soul to consider what it sends ahead for tomorrow (Q 59:18). Reciting them, he said, is "very effective for curing the soul and for holding the mischief of the self and Satan at bay"[67].

Forgotten together, known together

If the human story is the soul's story, losing sight of the soul is the deepest loss. Surah al-Hashr names its cause: forgetting God.

وَلَا تَكُونُوا۟ كَٱلَّذِينَ نَسُوا۟ ٱللَّهَ فَأَنسَىٰهُمْ أَنفُسَهُمْ ۚ أُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ هُمُ ٱلْفَٰسِقُونَ ﴿١٩﴾

Do not be like those who forget Allah, so He makes them forget their own souls. It is they who are the transgressors.

Qur'an 59:19

The verse calls such people transgressors. Sheikh Bahmanpour counts most of us, Muslims included, among those who have forgotten their souls. He does not mean that we will necessarily be punished for it. He means that we do not realise the potential our souls hold, and so we do not develop them as we could.

The mystics find the cure in the same verse. If forgetting God makes us forget the soul, remembering God (*dhikr*) turns our attention back to it. The return comes in stages. A person first turns back to the self and sees that it must have a Creator. Fuller knowledge of the soul comes later, as the remembrance of God deepens.

[65] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 8.
[66] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 8.
[67] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 201.

Where remembering God brings the soul back, losing the soul takes faith with it. Surah al-An‘am says so.

ٱلَّذِينَ خَسِرُوٓاْ أَنفُسَهُمۡ فَهُمۡ لَا يُؤۡمِنُونَ ﴿٢٠﴾

Those who have ruined their souls will not have faith.

Qur’an 6:20

A ruined soul loses faith because its owner can no longer see it. A soul that is seen points to its Maker. The body is put together from parts, and a person can suppose that it came about by an evolution of matter. The soul is not like that: as soon as it is seen, its Creator is seen.

Forgetting runs in both directions, and so does knowing. A saying handed down from the Prophet ﷺ, and from Imam ‘Ali (as), puts it in a single line.

من عرف نفسه فقد عرف ربه

Whoever knows his own self knows his Lord.[68]

Hadith

The saying holds because the soul reflects its Maker. God’s qualities are infinite and differ greatly from the soul’s. Yet there is a likeness, and through it God can be known by looking within. This does not make the soul a part of God. The soul carries something of the spirit (*ruh*) that God breathed into the first human being (Q 15:29). That spirit is something God created, not God Himself.

Knowing God therefore begins with knowing the soul. ‘Allama Tabataba’i ties this to a verse that tells believers to take care of their own souls (Q 5:105). He writes that a man who has access to Divine manifestation and wishes to remember Allah alone, on hearing this verse, “must see Allah through the window of his own soul”[69].

[68] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari‘a), p. 9; M. S. Bahmanpour, lecture slides, Irfan 1: Theory, “Human Soul” slide.

[69] Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 7.

ع WORD STUDY: WHOEVER KNOWS HIMSELF

The saying is short in Arabic: *man ʿarafa nafsahu faqad ʿarafa rabbahu*. Its verb, *ʿarafa* (to know), shares its root with maʿrifah and ʿirfan, and its *nafs* is the soul that Surah al-Shams swears by. Mohammad Ali Shomali writes that "it is difficult to find a book on ethics (Akhlaq), which has not quoted it"[70]. Some sources give it to the Prophet and others to Imam ʿAli (as). *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (as), gives it as the words of the Prophet[71]. Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi quotes it from Imam ʿAli (as)[72], and so do the slides for the lectures[73]. The saying has also been read two ways. Some take it as a denial: no one can know their own soul completely, so no one can know their Lord. Others take it as a promise: whoever comes to know his soul does come to know his Lord. The lectures accept the first reading but prefer the second. They point to other narrations, which show that the saying speaks of a knowledge we can reach.

Near already: lifting the veils

Looking within does not mean going anywhere, because God is already near. In Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "We are actually in His presence at the moment. However, He is not in our presence." The soul stands before God now. What it lacks is the perception of the One before whom it stands.

Reaching God therefore covers no distance. The journey to Him is a sharpening of the heart's sight, not a movement from one place to another. What stands between the soul and Him is a veil over the heart (*hijab*, plural *hujub*). Coming near to God (*qurb*) means having such a veil removed, and purification is what removes it. The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah asks that the eyes of our hearts penetrate even the veils of light[74]. Chapter Eight sets out these veils and the stages in which they are lifted.

At the meeting with God that the Qur'an promises, the veils will one day come off for every soul. Surah al-Anʿam warns those who deny that meeting.

[70] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, pp. 8–9.
[71] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 9.
[72] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 125.
[73] M. S. Bahmanpour, lecture slides, Irfan 1: Theory, "Human Soul" slide.
[74] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.

قَدْ خَسِرَ ٱلَّذِينَ كَذَّبُوا۟ بِلِقَآءِ ٱللَّهِ

They are certainly losers who deny the encounter with Allah.

Qur’an 6:31

The verse speaks of the meeting with God (*liqa’ Allah*). Every soul will take part in this meeting, believer or unbeliever, because every soul can perceive God. At the meeting, as the lectures put it, “We remove the layers that cover our soul”. Each of us will see our own soul as it is. Three things about that meeting matter to a seeker now: what the soul sees there, where its sight stops, and what decides how much it sees.

What is seen at that meeting is the soul, and the soul is a reflection of God. Seeing it is therefore seeing a reflection of God, and not God Himself. The verse still calls it a meeting with Him. On that day the soul perceives the presence it has always stood in. The believer perceives God’s mercy and reward, whereas the unbeliever perceives His justice.

Even then, the soul cannot encompass God. The depth of our own soul cannot be known, so a complete knowledge of its Lord is out of reach. As the lectures put it, “You can get some understanding but knowing Him completely ... is impossible.” Imam Khomeini sets a similar limit for the seeker. Those who hold that the meeting with God is open to the seeker, he writes, do not mean that it is permissible “to fathom the mystery of the Divine Essence”, or that the Essence can be encompassed in knowledge by presence[75].

STORY: MUSA ASKS TO SEE GOD

Sheikh Bahmanpour points briefly to the Prophet Musa (as) for a limit on perceiving God. The scene he has in mind is told in the Qur’an, in Surah al-A‘raf. Musa comes to the meeting God appointed for him, and his Lord speaks to him. Musa asks, “My Lord, show [Yourself] to me, that I may look at You!” God answers, “You shall not see Me” (لَن تَرَىٰنِي), and tells him to look at the mountain instead: if it stays in its place, Musa will see Him. God discloses Himself to the mountain and levels it, and Musa falls down in a swoon (Q 7:143). In the Sheikh’s words, “There is a degree of perception which could not be attained by this body”, and that is what Musa was asking for.

[75] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 398.

What a soul perceives of God at that meeting depends on what it perceives of Him now. In the lectures' words, "whoever is completely blind in this world is completely blind in the other world." The Qur'an uses the same image.

وَمَن كَانَ فِي هَٰذِهِۦٓ أَعۡمَىٰ فَهُوَ فِي ٱلۡأٓخِرَةِ أَعۡمَىٰ وَأَضَلُّ سَبِيلٗا ﴿٧٢﴾

But whoever has been blind in this [world], will be blind in the Hereafter, and [even] more astray from the [right] way.

Qur'an 17:72

The seeker therefore begins lifting the veils in this life. There is a second reason not to wait: the journey every soul makes through death is longer and harder than the one a seeker takes by choice. In the Sheikh's account, the many methods the mystics have devised all aim solely at removing the veil that covers the heart.

Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi describes what the seeker finds when the self is uncovered. The one given God's grace can "remove the material curtain from his spirit and self" and see the self's reality. For him, this knowledge of the self is the meaning of Imam ʿAli's (as) saying that whoever knows himself knows his Lord[76].

The way to God therefore runs through knowing and purifying our own self. God is already near and reflected in the soul, and the veil that keeps us from Him lies over the soul itself.

If the way to God runs through the self, how deep does the self go?

> **TRY THIS**
>
> After one of the daily prayers each day this week, recite the closing verses of Surah al-Hashr (Q 59:18–24) and reflect on their meaning. This was Shahabadi's practice for his pupils, as Imam Khomeini recalls: "Our Shaykh would ask us to recite these verses after daily prayers and to contemplate over their meaning, especially in the late hours of night when the heart is relaxed"[77]. As you read, notice the warning in verse 19, that forgetting God leads to forgetting your own soul, and the names of God with which the surah ends.

[76] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 125.
[77] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 201.

5

The soul and its worlds

إِلٰهِي إِنْ أَنَامَتْنِيَ ٱلْغَفْلَةُ عَنِ ٱلإِسْتِعْدَادِ لِلِقَائِكَ فَقَدْ نَبَّهَتْنِي ٱلْمَعْرِفَةُ بِكَرَمِ آلَائِكَ

My Lord, if my disregard for preparations to meet You has put me to sleep, my knowledge of Your kind bounties has awakened me.[78]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

At a graveside we say that the dead are now in *barzakh* (the world between this life and the resurrection), and we picture it as a waiting room far from the living realm. Sheikh Bahmanpour teaches the opposite: at death "we don't go anywhere". The dead are nearer than we think.

The dead are near because the next world is not far away. Creation holds more than one world, and they are layers of one reality: each is deeper than the last, not further away. Barzakh is one of these deeper worlds. Each night, in sleep, the soul already touches it. That is why *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (as), calls sleep "the brother of death"[79]. The prayer above makes the same link: it speaks of sleep and of meeting God together. At death the soul does not travel away; it goes into a deeper world.

[78] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 166; *Munajat Sha'baniyyah* (duas.org), §118–119.

[79] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari'a), p. 24.

This chapter sets out the soul and its worlds: which worlds creation holds; how the soul passes into them; how what we do gives the soul its form there; and why that form is, by God's grace, still in our hands.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *ʿalam al-mulk*: the material world · *ʿalam al-mithal* or *barzakh*: the middle world of images · *ʿalam al-ʿuqul*: the world of pure intellects · *badan mithali*: the image body · *muraqaba*: watchfulness; keeping the heart's attention on God

One world at three depths

Let's start with a claim of the mystics: the human soul is the whole of creation in small; it is a compact copy of everything that exists. If that is so, we can use the soul as a map of creation. Each kind of thing the soul holds has its counterpart in creation on a larger scale, and each such kind makes up a world of its own. By looking at the kinds of thing the soul holds, we can learn the kinds of world that creation holds.

The soul holds three kinds of thing, because it knows in three ways: through the senses, through the imagination, and through the intellect. Each way of knowing meets its own kind of thing. Taking them one at a time shows the three worlds.

The senses meet things made of matter: things with weight that take up space, such as a table, a hand, or the rain. These make up the first world, the material world (*ʿalam al-mulk*). Because our senses witness it, it is also called the witnessed world. The other two worlds are called unseen.

The imagination holds the second kind of thing. When we picture a friend's face, the picture has a shape and a colour, yet it weighs nothing and is made of nothing material. A dream does the same more vividly. Creation holds things of this kind on a larger scale, in the world of images (*ʿalam al-mithal*). Like the picture in our mind, that world has shape, size, and colour, and no matter at all. The difference is that the world of images is not inside anyone's mind. It is part of God's creation, and it exists whether or not anyone imagines it.

The intellect holds the third kind of thing: meanings, with no shape and no matter. Every person we have met has a particular height, voice, and face. Yet the mind can grasp "a human being" with none of these features. No such featureless person exists anywhere outside the mind. Creation holds pure

meanings of this kind in the world of intellects (*ʿalam al-ʿuqul*). The angels who live there are pure intellect, attached to nothing material.

Creation therefore has three worlds that the soul mirrors, one for each of its ways of knowing. The world of images stands between the other two as a middle world. That is why it is also called *barzakh*, "a barrier". Pure intellect and matter cannot meet directly. Whatever is in the world of intellects is reflected first in the world of images, which has the shape and colour of matter without its weight. Only then does it reach the world of matter. Above all three, the lectures place higher realms that encompass them: the Footstool (*kursi*), the Throne (*ʿarsh*), and the world of *jabarut*.

These three worlds are not places we travel to. In Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, the world of images "is another dimension of the same world in which we are living", and so is the world of intellects. The two deeper worlds are unseen not because they are far away but because the ordinary eye does not perceive them without training. The unseen worlds surround this one, but in depth and not in distance: each is a deeper dimension of the world we are in now.

Imam ʿAli (as) described this world as lying inside the hereafter when a Christian churchman came to him with questions. One of them, as the lectures tell it, was whether the hereafter lies inside this world, or this world inside the hereafter. Imam ʿAli (as) answered that this world lies inside the hereafter: this world is limited, and the hereafter encompasses it. The lectures set the answer beside a verse that says hell, which belongs to the hereafter, surrounds the faithless (Q 9:49). If this world lies inside the hereafter, the hereafter is not somewhere else. It surrounds this world now, like an envelope.

The soul mirrors three worlds, then, one inside another, and together they make one reality. The senses meet matter, the imagination meets the world of images, and the intellect grasps pure meaning. Each world lies deeper than the one before, and none of them is far away.

> **ع WORD STUDY: BARZAKH**
> A *barzakh* is a barrier, something that stands between two things and keeps each in its place. The Qur'an uses the word for the barrier God set between two seas that He merged, one sweet and one briny (Q 25:53). It also uses it of death.

One of the deniers, when death comes, asks to be sent back so that he may act righteously, and he is refused. Before such people, the verse says, is a barrier until the day they are resurrected (Q 23:99–100). The ‘urafa’ use the same word for the world of images, which stands between matter and pure intellect. Mohammad Ali Shomali notes that philosophers compare the body of that world with the bodies we see in dreams, and “call them ‘Barzakh’ or ‘mithali’”[80]. The tradition joins the two uses: the middle world is called barzakh because it stands between matter and intellect, and it is where the dead are until the resurrection.

A soul that crosses them

The soul has a share in each of these worlds because it stands between the spirit God breathed into us and the body. The Qur’an says God breathed of His spirit into the first human being (Q 15:29). God is not made of parts, so the spirit is called His out of honour, as the Kaʿba is called His house. This spirit is the greatest of His creations. Pure spirit and matter cannot meet directly. The soul is the means by which that spirit reaches the body, as the world of images links intellect and matter. It therefore touches matter through the body and can enter the middle world.

For now, the body holds almost all of the soul’s attention, so the soul lives in the material world and the deeper worlds pass unnoticed. That hold loosens at three times: in sleep, at death, and in watchfulness. Taking them one at a time shows where the soul goes when the hold loosens.

The first is sleep. When we sleep, the soul attends less to the body. With the senses at rest, it can touch the world of images. It does not leave the body completely. If it did, we would be dead. This explains how a dream can show more than memory holds. A person may dream of something that later happens, and memory cannot show the future. Time works differently in the middle world. The soul has seen there the counterpart of an event that has not yet happened here.

The second is death, which the Qur’an sets beside sleep. Surah al-Zumar names the two together.

[80] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 76.

ٱللَّهُ يَتَوَفَّى ٱلْأَنفُسَ حِينَ مَوْتِهَا وَٱلَّتِي لَمْ تَمُتْ فِي مَنَامِهَا ۖ

Allah takes the souls at the time of their death, and those who have not died, in their sleep.

Qur’an 39:42

In both, the verse says, God takes the soul. The difference is one of degree. Mohammad Ali Shomali explains that in sleep the connection with the body remains, “but to a lesser degree than waking”[81].

At death the soul lets go of the body completely. Shomali writes that it then “belongs to another body which has the qualities of a material body like shape and size without the mass”[82]. This second body is the image body (*badan mithali*). “The body is not carrying the soul but the soul is carrying the body,” Sheikh Bahmanpour says. When the appointed time comes, the soul sets the body down. It does not go on without a body, because a soul cannot be without one. It goes on in the image body, which was with us all along, unseen in another dimension.

The third is watchfulness (*muraqaba*): keeping the heart’s attention on God. It happens while we are awake. A person who turns their attention to God until they forget the body does on purpose what sleep does. They can then see into the middle world as one sees in a dream. ‘Allama Tabataba’i said that the more he kept up his muraqaba, the more distinctly he saw into that world. Such moments come to the mystics as an opportunity from God and not as a power to use. Only the Imams (as), the lectures add, can pass between the worlds whenever they wish.

STORY: QADI MEETS HIMSELF

Kernel of the Kernels, the record of ‘Allama Tabataba’i’s lectures on the path, describes what may come to a traveller who keeps up muraqaba. Lights appear, at first like flashes of lightning, and “these lights belong to the class of entities of the realm of Barzakh”. In the early stages the traveller may see his own soul in bodily form: “he might see himself standing before himself.” Tabataba’i then recalls his own teacher, Mirza ‘Ali Aqa Qadi, who used to say: “One day emerging from the room into the veranda, I saw myself standing silent by my side. I

[81] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 75.
[82] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 76.

> looked very carefully at my face, and observed a mole on it. On returning to my room when I looked into the mirror, I saw that there was a mole on my face that I had not noticed until then"[83].

Sleep, death, and watchfulness are three ways of loosening one hold. In sleep the hold slackens for a night, and in watchfulness a person loosens it on purpose. At death it lets go entirely. Each time, the soul reaches the world of images, and at death it stays there.

This changes the picture at the graveside. The dead are in barzakh, which is the world of images; it is the middle world the soul enters when the hold of the body loosens. That world is not a distant room. It is a deeper dimension of the world we are living in, so the dead have gone deeper into our world, not away from it.

Our deeds give the soul a form

The soul's movement between worlds sets it apart from the angels of the world of intellects. Each angel has a fixed station that it cannot rise above. An angel does not change or grow, because it is made as it will always be. Surah al-Saffat gives their own words.

وَمَا مِنَّآ إِلَّا لَهُۥ مَقَامٌ مَّعْلُومٌ ﴿١٦٤﴾

There is none among us but has a known place.

Qur'an 37:164

The human soul has no known place of this kind. It can move and change, and no one knows how far it can go. The mystics say that this capacity is why the angels bowed down to Adam. A soul that is not fixed in advance can be shaped, and how far it goes depends on the life it lives.

What shapes such a soul is what it does, and above all what it does again and again. Shomali takes the example of lying. A child telling a first lie feels uneasy and later remorseful. With repetition "the soul becomes inured to the

[83] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 17.

effects”[84], until lying costs little effort. The act has become a habit, and the habit has become part of the soul.

Some of that shaping shows on the face. A face can show faith or its absence to those with eyes to see it. In this world, though, the change is slow and small, and it does not deform the body. The image body is far more sensitive. Sin deforms it and piety makes it shine.

The form the soul has when it leaves this world is the form it keeps in the next, as Imam Khomeini writes in his *Forty Hadith*. Beside the body that everyone can see, each person has “another form and a different face of him, which is heavenly and invisible, which is determined by the qualities of his soul and his inner nature”[85]. The same page names the moment that settles it: “in whichever state one’s soul departs from the body, it assumes a form suited to it in the next world also”[86].

The Qur’an points the same way. Surah al-Naba’ describes people coming forth on the Last Day.

يَوْمَ يُنفَخُ فِي ٱلصُّورِ فَتَأْتُونَ أَفْوَاجًا ﴿١٨﴾

the day the Trumpet will be blown, and you will come in groups,

Qur’an 78:18

Hadith reports say that the groups are formed “according to their true natures”[87]. Surah al-Hadid describes how the faithful will appear.

يَوْمَ تَرَى ٱلْمُؤْمِنِينَ وَٱلْمُؤْمِنَٰتِ يَسْعَىٰ نُورُهُم بَيْنَ أَيْدِيهِمْ وَبِأَيْمَٰنِهِم

The day you will see the faithful, men and women, with their light moving swiftly in front of them and on their right

Qur’an 57:12

The lectures read this light as the shining of the pious themselves. The body of the Last Day, they note, is not the image body, yet piety makes both shine.

[84]Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 20.
[85]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 41.
[86]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 41.
[87]Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 21.

On the Last Day that light goes ahead of the faithful to light the way. In both verses, people appear as what their souls have become.

If the light of the faithful is their own piety shining, then some rewards are the deeds themselves, made visible. Shomali states this as a general principle about reward and punishment: "Sometimes rewards or punishments are nothing other than the actions. They are just the realities of those actions made manifest in another universe"[88]. A deed done here has a reality in the middle world, and Ibn ʿArabi once met such a reality face to face.

STORY: IBN ʿARABI AND SURAH YASIN

Sheikh Bahmanpour tells a story that the great mystic Ibn ʿArabi told of his own childhood. At the age of twelve he fell seriously ill and went into a coma. It was so serious that everyone thought he had died. In that state he saw horrible-looking people who were trying to hurt him. Then a figure breathing out a wonderful perfume defended him and drove them away. The boy asked who he was. The figure answered that he was Surah Yasin, his protector. When the boy came round, he found his father at his bedside in tears. His father had just finished reciting Surah Yasin for his recovery, and the boy had not known. In this telling, the figure was the image the recitation had formed in barzakh, for anything we do here has an image there. A lie or a word of comfort seems to be only words, yet each takes a shape in barzakh, as real as the figure the boy saw.

If some rewards are the deeds themselves, the form a soul meets after death is, in part, the work of its own deeds. Shomali puts it briefly: "our future is now present"[89]. What we do now shapes the image body, and every prayer, lie, or word of comfort has its own image in barzakh.

The self can change its state

The soul that does these deeds is what the Qur'an calls the self (*nafs*), and it is not fixed in one state. The Qur'an gives it three names, and the lectures read them as three states. Let's take them from lowest to highest, to see how the self can move.

The lowest is the self that commands to evil (*nafs al-ammara*). In it the bodily side of a person overcomes the spiritual side, and the soul goes after the

[88] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 77.
[89] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 77.

body's pleasures. Surah Yusuf names this self together with the mercy that can lift it.

إِنَّ ٱلنَّفْسَ لَأَمَّارَةٌۢ بِٱلسُّوٓءِ إِلَّا مَا رَحِمَ رَبِّيٓ ۚ

the [carnal] soul indeed prompts [men] to evil, except inasmuch as my Lord has mercy.

Qur'an 12:53

The verse admits what this self does and names what overcomes it: the mercy of God. The pull of this self is not only towards pleasure. Worry also binds the soul to the body, whether it is thought given to our own employment, our children's futures, or other wider concerns. Worry keeps the soul occupied with the body and stops it rising towards God.

After giving in, the self may remember what it did and ask why. This is the second state, the self that blames itself (*nafs al-lawwama*). Its self-blame is a hopeful sign, because it shows that we hold values that matter more to us than the pleasure we gave in to. Surah al-Qiyama swears by it.

وَلَآ أُقْسِمُ بِٱلنَّفْسِ ٱللَّوَّامَةِ ﴿٢﴾

And I swear by the self-critical soul!

Qur'an 75:2

A self that keeps up its self-blame comes in time to the third state, the self at peace (*nafs al-mutma'inna*). Surah al-Fajr calls this self back to its Lord (Q 89:27–28). It relies on what belongs to the hereafter and not on this world. It is free of sin, of greed, and of a mind turned wholly towards the body.

These are not three selves. "We don't have different types of nufus," Sheikh Bahmanpour says, using the plural of nafs. The one self takes a different name according to its attitude. Because we can change the attitude, we can change the state, and with it the name.

ع WORD STUDY: THE LAYERS OF THE SOUL, COUNTED DIFFERENTLY

Murtada Mutahhari writes that the ʿurafa' "have different words for the human soul", and he sets out four. When the soul is "dominated and ruled by desires and passions they call it nafs". When it bears divine knowledge it is the heart (*qalb*). When "the light of Divine love dawns within it", it is the spirit (*ruh*), and when it reaches witnessing it is the secret (*sirr*). Beyond these lie the hidden (*khafi*) and the most hidden (*akhfa*)[90]. The lectures order them differently, describing the sirr as known only to God and the khafi as hidden even from the angels. Sayyid Haydar Amuli, a Shia master, counts the states of the self differently too, with four where the lectures have three. In his *Inner Secrets of the Path* the self ascends through "commanding to evil", "reproachful", "inspired", and "at rest"[91]. Imam Khomeini notes that the soul's levels are divided "sometimes into seven sections and sometimes into four", and sometimes into three or two[92]. The lists count different things (names, states, and levels). Read together, they describe one soul seen in different ways. Chapter Eight takes nafs, qalb, and ruh as stages of the road.

The attitude is changed by acts already familiar to us. Two of them show how this works: the remembrance of God, and fasting with the night prayer.

The first is the remembrance of God (*dhikr*), which the lectures describe as refreshing and reviving the soul. Surah al-Raʿd names what it gives.

أَلَا بِذِكْرِ ٱللَّهِ تَطْمَئِنُّ ٱلْقُلُوبُ ﴿٢٨﴾

Behold! The hearts find rest in Allah's remembrance!

Qur'an 13:28

In Arabic, the verse's word for finding rest comes from the same root as *mutma'inna*, the name of the self at peace (Q 13:28; 89:27). The rest that remembrance brings is the rest of the third state.

The second is fasting, with the night prayer beside it. Both loosen the body's hold on the soul, as sleep and watchfulness do. It is that hold that makes the self command to evil. The soul manages the body, down to digesting a meal, so a fasting body asks less of it. In Ramadan God pours down His light everywhere. The soul of the one who fasts is less taken up with the body, and it

[90] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 58.
[91] Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 192.
[92] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 32.

takes in that light without knowing it. The night prayer (*salat al-layl*) likewise helps the soul free itself from the body and see the light.

A change made this way lasts, because the soul takes on habits quickly. Trained to worry about the body, it worries about the body. Trained to care for higher things, it comes to care for them and to see the light. In the lectures' image, the soul is like a fine elastic thing. It can be held in the palm of a hand or stretched to the size of the universe, and which of the two it becomes depends on what we do with it. It has been entrusted to us for a short time. Whatever we do with it, Sheikh Bahmanpour says, "would remain with us forever".

The soul is therefore deeper than it looks. It mirrors three worlds of creation, one inside another, and none of them is far away. When the body's hold loosens, the soul passes into the middle world, and at death it stays there. Its deeds give it a form that it will meet there. The self that does those deeds can move from commanding to blaming to peace. What the soul finally becomes has been entrusted to us. The drive to begin is itself God's grace, the mercy that Surah Yusuf named. The rest of the work is in our hands.

If the work on the soul is this inward, what keeps it from going astray?

> **TRY THIS**
>
> *Lantern of the Path* gives an intention for going to sleep. For one week, as you lie down each night, make it your own: "to lighten your burden on the angels and disengage the self from its appetites, and to examine yourself by your sleep"[93]. With it, the Lantern asks you to "be aware of the fact that you are incapable and weak. You have no power over any of your movements and stillnesses, except by the judgement and measure of Allah"[94]. Let sleep be your "last affair in this world", and remember Allah "with your heart and your tongue" before it comes[95].

[93] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 24.
[94] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 24.
[95] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 25.

6

No path outside the law

وَلاَ يَغْفُلُ عَنْ شُكْرِكَ وَلاَ يَسْتَخِفُّ بِأَمْرِكَ

who do not fail to show You their gratitude and do not take Your orders lightly[96]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

These words come near the end of the Munajat Sha'baniyyah. The words just before them ask to be among those who always remember God. This line adds two more requests: never to fail to thank Him, and never to take His commands lightly. Remembering God and keeping His commands are asked for together.

In our own prayers the two often come apart. We stand for salah, raise our hands, and say *Allahu akbar*, and within moments the mind is asking whether the car was locked. The law judges the outward form of the prayer, and the form was correct, so the prayer is valid in law.

That gap can lead to a tempting conclusion. The journey towards God is an inward one, worked out in the self. If the remembering is what matters, and the rules can be kept without it, perhaps the rules are an outer layer to be

[96]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 166; *Munajat Sha'baniyyah* (duas.org), §126–127.

left behind as the traveller goes deeper. Some mystical traditions have taught exactly this: train the heart, and do not trouble over the details of the law.

Most of the masters of the path in Islam, Shia and Sunni alike, taught the opposite. This chapter sets out why there is no path outside the law. Seen at different depths, the rules we keep and the remembering we lose belong to one religion. The deeper levels are reached only through the law, and the law is kept to the end of the road.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *sharīʿa*: the sacred law; what the Prophet ﷺ taught us to do · *tariqa*: the path; the inward way of doing what the law asks · *haqiqa*: the truth that the path leads to · *karamat*: wonders worked by those close to God

Shell, core, and kernel

Let's start with the three words the 'urafa' use for the depths of the religion. The first is the law (*sharīʿa*): how and when to pray and to fast, and what each act needs before it is valid. It is what the Prophet ﷺ taught us to do, and it is what most of us mean by practising the religion.

The law is not kept for its own sake. We pray and fast to draw near to God, and the way from the law to that nearness is called the path (*tariqa*). The path leads in turn to the truth (*haqiqa*), the reality that is seen once the path has been walked.

The path is not a second set of acts beside the law. Suppose we prayed beside the Prophet ﷺ and copied every movement he made. A jurist would rule both prayers valid, having checked the form of each: the standing, the bowing, and the words. The outward form of an act is all a jurist can judge, and both forms were the same.

What a jurist cannot judge is what passed in the heart. Imam Khomeini draws the same line: "there is no necessary relation between the (legal) validity of 'ibadah and its acceptability"[97]. An act of worship can be valid in law and still not be accepted, because acceptance turns on what the jurist cannot see. The Prophet's prayer and ours would differ in the inward way each was performed, and that inward way is the path. The outward frame of the act is still the law. What the Prophet saw through such a prayer is the truth.

[97] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 293.

A saying attributed to the Prophet ﷺ puts the three in one line. "The shari'ah is my words, tariqah my actions, haqiqah my states"[98]. His words tell us what to do. His actions show how it is done from within, and his states are what he saw by doing it.

If the path and the truth lie inside the law, the three are not separate roads. Mulla 'Abd al-Samad Hamadani, a Shia 'arif, taught that they are different names for one reality seen from different sides. They differ only in depth: the law is the shell, the path the core, and the truth the kernel.[99]

Hamadani found all three depths in a single salah. As service to God (*khidma*), the prayer belongs to the law. As a drawing near (*qurb*), it belongs to the path, and as an arrival (*wusul*), it belongs to the truth.[100] Sheikh Bahmanpour adds that a prayer like the Prophet's does all three at once: it serves God, it draws near to Him, and it arrives (*wusul*).

The order between the depths runs one way only. The law can be kept without the path. The prayer with the wandering mind was valid in law, yet it did not draw near. The path cannot be walked without the law, because the path is the inside of the law's own acts and has nothing else to work on.[101]

Each depth is therefore reached only through the one before it, and none can be skipped. Sheikh Bahmanpour credits an image for this to Najm al-Din Kubra, the head of one of the Sufi orders. The law is a ship, the path is a sea, and the truth is a pearl in that sea. The pearl "cannot be found except by sailing through the sea, and you cannot sail without a ship".

The inner never cancels the outer

If the truth is reached only through the law, someone who claims the truth while setting the law aside has left the ship. Kubra draws this conclusion from his own image. Suppose a person is seen flying through the air, walking on the sea, or eating fire. In the Sheikh's rendering of his words, if they have

[98] Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 32.

[99] Murtada Mutahhari gives the same order: "One is outward shell, another is inward kernel, and the third is the kernel of the kernel." Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 15.

[100] Sayyid Haydar Amuli records the saying: "Surely prayer is service, a coming closer and an arrival." Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 32.

[101] Sayyid Haydar Amuli puts the order as a rule: "shari'ah is possible without tariqah although tariqah is not possible without shari'ah." Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 48.

abandoned "even one injunction of God", then "you should know that they are liars".

"Liars" does not mean that the feats are faked, because such things can be done. The lie is in the claim to be a true ʿarif, one who knows God. The person works these wonders for their own desires, and what they do is not a wonder of the friends of God (*karama*) but magic (*sihr*).

> ع **WORD STUDY: KARAMAT, MUʿJIZA, AND SIHR**
> Three words name wonders that can look alike. A miracle (*muʿjiza*) is worked only by a prophet, by God's permission. A *karama* (plural *karamat*) is a wonder at the hands of someone close to God, or of someone who has found the spiritual power of the soul. Sheikh Bahmanpour describes it as worked through the strength of the human soul. Magic (*sihr*) produces effects that can look the same by other means, usually with the help of the jinn. Such a feat can look the same whoever performs it. Kubra's test therefore looks past the feat to the person's keeping of the law, and one abandoned command of God marks the feat as magic.

The claim to know God fails without the law because of what the law does to the one who keeps it. Ayatullah Muhammad Bahari, an Iranian ʿarif, set out the order. Jurisprudence, he taught, is "an introductory means" to purifying one's character. Good character, in turn, is the way into knowledge of God's oneness (*tawhid*).

Each link in that order needs the one before it. Theology can be learned in a classroom, but the reality of God cannot. It is found only through purifying the self, so without good character there is no knowledge of God. Without the law lived in oneself there is no good character. Some travellers claim to be ʿarifs with no further need of the law, as if it were meant only for ordinary people. On this chain of reasoning, they have broken its first link.

Imam Khomeini reaches the same conclusion through the image of light: "Without adhering to the apparent teachings of Islam it is not possible that the light of the Divine Knowledge could descend upon his heart"[102]. Knowledge of God comes to the heart as a light, and a heart that has set the law aside is not made ready to receive it.

[102]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 35.

What does come without the law is easily mistaken for that light. Sheikh Bahmanpour, recalling a remark of ʻAllama Tabataba'i's, warns that anyone of any belief will find something if they go forty days on less and less food. The knowledge of God is so unfamiliar to us that whatever is found is taken for God.

Even the light of an ablution can be taken for the light of God. The Sheikh tells of a great mystic whose chain of teachers went back to Imam al-Rida (as). One day, as he was making his ritual ablution (*wudu*), his disciples suddenly fell into prostration, glorifying God. When he asked what had happened, one of them said he had seen the light of God. The master told them it was the light of his wudu. The light of God is unknown to most of us, and so they took this one for His.

Even the experiences that come on the true path are not the goal. Tabataba'i's lectures on the path were recorded by his student Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Tihrani in *Kernel of the Kernels*. There the states a traveller passes through, and the lights that appear from time to time, are called "a preliminary to an enduring condition"[103]. An experience comes and goes. What counts is a lasting change in the self. Until the change is lasting, "the smallest lapse in wayfaring and spiritual jihad would bring him down again to the lower world"[104].

A forty-day exercise does not make that lasting change. In the remark the Sheikh recalls, the harder discipline is practising the law without a break. It asks for worship every day and night and at every dawn. It asks for a constant watch over the tongue, which might backbite, and the ears, which might listen to what is vile. A forty-day exercise ends, whereas the law is kept for a whole life. The lasting change comes from that keeping, not from any wonder or experience, and the real ʻarif is the one who keeps the law continuously.

The first inner work

That lifelong keeping is also where the first inner work is done, inside the prayers we already pray. The path purifies the way we practise the law, giving each act more depth each time it is done. It begins with the first words of the

[103] ʻAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[104] ʻAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 31.

prayer: at *Allahu akbar*, we have to know what we are saying. Once we do, the words begin to work inside us as we say them.

Knowing what we are saying needs attention, and attention cannot be held by force. We can close our eyes and keep our tongue still, yet the moment we turn towards God, the thought about the car arrives.

Logically this should not happen, because standing before God ought to hold the mind as standing at the edge of a cliff does. Someone at a cliff's edge would not wonder whether the car was locked, because the danger is in front of them. Yet no one can bring that sense of presence to prayer simply by deciding to.

The difficulty is a circle. To bring that sense of presence to the words, we need a knowledge that comes only after they have been practised and taken in. That practice needs the same attention that keeps slipping. This circle is the whole difficulty of the path. Anyone can perform the acts the law asks for, but the path asks for this attention as well, which is why it is harder to walk.

The circle does not mean that the faculty of attention is missing. Imam Khomeini asks, "How is it that the study of a book often absorbs man's entire attention, but prayer does not?"[105]. The question itself shows that the mind can be held, since a book holds it. On this reading, what is missing is the habit of bringing that attention to prayer.

That habit is built inside the law. In *Forty Hadith* he names two things that bring attention to worship: "possessing unoccupied time and an unoccupied heart", and "making one's heart understand the importance of worship"[106]. He is plain about what is at stake, writing that "a worship performed without an attentive heart is devoid of value"[107]. The path builds the habit a degree at a time, giving each prayer a little more depth than the last, and Chapter Ten takes up the remembrances that carry this attention beyond the prayer.

To the last breath

The law holds at the start of the road, and it holds at the end. Some have claimed that a traveller who reaches the higher stations is spared the obliga-

[105] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 135.
[106] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 375.
[107] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 375.

tions of the law. Tabataba'i's teaching, as the *Kernel* records it, rejects the claim outright: "from the beginning of wayfaring to its final stage the wayfarer must abide by all the precepts of the luminous Shari'ah"[108]. The claim of release is "a big lie and slander"[109].

The proof is the Prophet ﷺ. Though he was the noblest of all creation, he kept every precept of the law until the last moments of his life[110]. If the one who reached furthest was never released from the law, no traveller reaches a station where it stops applying.

The *Kernel*'s test is close to Kubra's. Anyone who claims to be a wayfarer while departing from the law even slightly is to be considered a hypocrite. The only allowance is for a lapse that comes from error, from an excuse, or from forgetfulness[111].

Imam Khomeini goes further. A person to whom the truth has been unveiled, he writes, acts "with greater observance of the manifest forms of religion"[112]. He rejects the claim of release, the view that once inner excellences are gained the outward forms are no longer obligatory, as "a mistaken conception born of ignorance about the stages of worship"[113].

Worship does have stages, and the *Kernel* finds one true sense in the talk of release, though not the sense its proponents intend. Acts of worship develop the soul, bringing its capacities "from potentiality to actuality"[114], that is, making real what was only possible. For a soul still growing towards its perfection, worship is the means of growth. For a soul that has reached perfection, worship is no longer for growth[115]. What changes on arrival is not the law but the reason for keeping it.

The Prophet ﷺ gave that reason himself. He was once asked why he took such pains in worship when God had promised him forgiveness (Q 48:2), and he answered with a question.

---

[108] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[109] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[110] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[111] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[112] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 35.
[113] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 35.
[114] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[115] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.

Don't you want me to be God's grateful servant?[116]

Hadith

For such a soul, the *Kernel* concludes, worship is "purely for the sake of expression of thankfulness and gratitude to God Almighty"[117]. The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah at the head of this chapter asks for the same gratitude: to be among those who do not fail to show God their gratitude and do not take His orders lightly.

The completed journey also runs past arrival. The 'urafa' describe it as four journeys: to God, in God, back from God to creation, and among creation. In the Sheikh's phrase, the last three are made "by the haqq", that is, through God, the Real, and not by the traveller's own strength. The traveller returns to creation in the third journey and travels the fourth among people, as Chapter Sixteen describes. On the *Kernel*'s rule that the law binds the wayfarer "to its final stage"[118], it binds in these journeys too.

There is therefore no path outside the law. The law, the path, and the truth belong to one religion, seen at three depths, and each depth is reached only through the one before. Nothing inward stands in for the law, and the inner work begins inside it, with attention in prayer. After arrival the law is still kept, now as thanks to God.

If the law marks out the road, who walks it beside the traveller?

> **➤ TRY THIS**
>
> For one prayer each day this week, keep its time free, with nothing planned straight after it. Imam Khomeini advises that one "should set aside a certain time out of his day and night hours exclusively for the sake of worship", and that the prayer be carried out "in the most meritorious part of its time"[119]. At *Allahu akbar*, follow Sheikh Bahmanpour's advice and "know what you are saying". When the mind turns to something else, bring it back to the words of the prayer.

[116] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[117] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[118] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[119] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 375.

7

Finding a guide

The Mafatih recommends reading Surah al-Kahf on Fridays[120]. Halfway through it, the Prophet Musa (as) sets out to find a servant of God whom, God says, He had taught "a knowledge from Our own" (Q 18:65). This servant is known as Khidr[121]. Musa is ready to keep travelling until he reaches the meeting place of the two seas, or has spent a long time (Q 18:60). When he finds the servant, he makes one request.

قَالَ لَهُۥ مُوسَىٰ هَلْ أَتَّبِعُكَ عَلَىٰٓ أَن تُعَلِّمَنِ مِمَّا عُلِّمْتَ رُشْدًا ﴿٦٦﴾

Moses said to him, 'May I follow you for the purpose that you teach me some of the probity you have been taught?'

Qur'an 18:66

In this verse a prophet to whom God spoke directly (Q 4:164) asks to be taught. His long search shows how much time and effort a seeker must be ready to give. Travellers on the road to God can look for the same kind of help. The law marks the boundary of that road, and the next question is who walks

[120] Shaykh 'Abbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, pp. 84–85.
[121] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 508.

beside the traveller on it. This chapter sets out why finding a guide helps the traveller, and how to know a true guide once found.

WORDS YOU’LL MEET *shaykh*: a spiritual master · *murid*: a disciple · *silsila*: a chain of masters traced back to the Prophet ﷺ · *wali* (plural *awliya’*): a friend of God · *wusul*: arrival at the goal of the road

Why a traveller needs a companion

A guide helps because the road has turns that a traveller cannot read alone, and those turns are in the soul. On the journey the soul can pass into strange states. There may come a time when a traveller hates worship, or cannot bear to live among people. Such states arrive without explanation. A traveller who does not know what they mean, or what to do next, can lose the way.

Someone who has already passed through these states can explain them. The traveller describes the state and is told what it means and what to do next. The advice can be as exact as whether *Allahu akbar* or *la ilaha illa Allah* is the remembrance that suits that stage. This is why a guide must have travelled the road himself, and not only studied it.

How early in the journey this need begins is where scholars differ, and three accounts, taken in turn, show the range. Many who want to set out look first for a teacher and, finding none, conclude that they cannot begin. Sheikh Bahmanpour does not tell a beginner to find a guide first. In his account the first steps are the law: “First you have to comply completely with whatever Sharia tells.” The guide who can read the soul’s states is found after those steps, not before. The Sufi orders tell a beginner that anything done without their instruction will leave him lost, which he calls “something of an exaggeration”.

What a beginner does need is narrower: a teacher who says which of the practices handed down in the hadith matter most. The Musabbihat are the five surahs that open with God’s glorification, recited by the Prophet ﷺ every night before sleeping. Mirza ‘Ali Aqa Qadi, the teacher of ‘Allama Tabataba’i, had beginners recite them every night before sleep for a whole year, and only then gave them a second instruction.

STORY: ‘UNWAN AL-BASRI AT THE DOOR OF IMAM AL-SADIQ

> ʿUnwan al-Basri was an old man, near the end of his life, when he asked Imam al-Sadiq (as) to teach him. Sheikh Bahmanpour tells the hadith. The sixth Imam at first turned him away. He was busy, he said, with words of remembrance he recited at every hour of the day, and ʿUnwan should go and learn from Malik ibn Anas and the other scholars of Medina. The lectures explain that ʿUnwan was not yet at a level where the Imam could teach him. ʿUnwan did not give up, instead praying that God would soften the heart of Imam al-Sadiq (as) towards him, so that he could learn something. When he went back, the Imam received him warmly and began to advise him. Among the first counsels were rules for eating: do not eat unless you are hungry, and when you do eat, eat only what is lawful and begin in the name of God. The teacher ʿUnwan had persisted in seeking began by giving him rules to start with.

ʿAllama Tabataba'i places the need for a teacher at the beginning of the road. In the lectures recorded in *Kernel of the Kernels*, he distinguishes a general teacher, consulted as one consults anyone learned, from the teachers God has appointed. Of the general teacher he says: "The necessity of referring to the general teacher is only at the beginning of wayfaring"[122]. Once the traveller reaches the higher stations, that teacher's company is no longer needed.

Murtada Mutahhari describes the practice of ʿirfan as guided at every stage. Each stage is passed under the guidance of "a mature and perfect example of humanity who, having traveled this path, is aware of the manners and ways of each station". Without such a guide, the traveller "is in danger of going astray". The ʿurafa', he reports, call this guide Khidr, and he quotes a couplet: "Leave not this stage without the company of Khidr, / There is darkness ahead; be afraid of losing the way"[123].

The three accounts place the need at different points, but they do not change what the guide is for: to read states the traveller has not yet passed through. Only someone who has travelled the road can do that, like the Khidr of the couplet, whose company keeps the traveller from losing the way.

[122] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 80; Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 100.

[123] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 10.

Under the Imams, not in their place

If a guide is needed, the next question is what authority he holds. The Sufi orders give one answer. Each order calls itself a path (*tariqa*) and is built round an elder with his own method of instruction, and each has a chain of masters (*silsila*) that it traces back to the Prophet ﷺ. Through that chain, the orders hold, the Prophet's inner knowledge passed from heart to heart, from each master to the next.

Shia agree that the Prophet's inner knowledge passed on, but hold that it passed by inheritance to the Imams (as). Imam ʿAli (as) received it as the Prophet's heir, not as one learned companion among others. The orders keep the idea of someone who receives that knowledge, Sheikh Bahmanpour observes. Their chains go back to Imam ʿAli (as), some of them through Imam al-Rida (as)[124]. Yet they do not hold, as Shia do, that the knowledge passed by inheritance to the Imams. For Shia the Imams hold that place, and so, in his words, "We don't have such a thing as tariqa in Shia."

The orders also ask for total submission. In an order, a disciple (*murid*) submits to the master (*shaykh*) completely, whatever he says and whatever he does. As a rule, Shia travellers do not join an order. They find an instructor for themselves, one who comes from no order and holds no special licence to instruct. What they look for is a person they can trust, someone to whom "you could entrust your soul".

ʿAllama Tabataba'i's two kinds of teacher, the general and the special, show where such an instructor stands. The instructor the Sheikh describes fits the first, the general teacher. Such a teacher has not been specially appointed to guide anyone. Consulting him is like consulting anyone knowledgeable, as a verse of Surah al-Nahl tells believers to do[125].

[124] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 87–88.

[125] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 80; Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 100.

فَسْـَٔلُوٓاْ أَهْلَ ٱلذِّكْرِ إِن كُنتُمْ لَا تَعْلَمُونَ ﴿٤٣﴾

Ask the People of the Reminder if you do not know.

Qur'an 16:43

The verse is general, but Tabataba'i sets a high bar for anyone a traveller submits to. A man is not a teacher "so long as the revelations of Divine Essence ... are not manifested in him", and the revelations of God's Attributes and Names are not enough[126]. Short of that rank, "one may not surrender oneself to everyone and anyone and submit and obey him"[127]. Anyone knowledgeable may be consulted, but only a teacher who has reached that rank may be submitted to.

The special teacher is different. He is one of those "specially designated to guide, and they are the Apostle of Allah and his true successors": the Prophet ﷺ and the Imams (as)[128]. "The wayfarer cannot dispense with the company of the special teacher in any circumstance whatsoever, even if he has reached his sought homeland"[129]. The company meant is inner, and not "merely their outward company and comradeship". It lasts through every stage of the road and after its end[130].

A guide therefore walks beside the traveller under the Imams (as), and never in their place. A traveller submits to him only if he has reached the rank Tabataba'i describes, whereas the company that never ends is that of the Prophet and the Imams. Chapter Fifteen returns to the Sufi orders and how the Shia path differs from them.

Teachers of recent generations

If Shia travellers find an instructor for themselves, there must be instructors to find. The tradition can name teachers who walked this road in recent generations. 'Allama Tabataba'i named his own teacher: "My preceptor was

[126] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 82; Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 101.

[127] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 83; Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 102.

[128] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 80.

[129] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 80.

[130] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 80–81; Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 100.

the late Haji Mirza Ali Agha Qazi"[131]. This is the same Mirza ʿAli Aqa Qadi who set beginners a year of the Musabbihat. Under him Tabataba'i travelled the path[132].

Qadi's line runs back two generations, to Akhund Mulla Husayn-Quli Hamadani, a different scholar from Mulla ʿAbd al-Samad Hamadani, who saw the law, the path, and the truth in one prayer. Akhund Hamadani had been one of the outstanding pupils of the jurist Shaykh Murtada Ansari before he became a guide[133]. He trained several pupils who became guides in turn, among them Qadi's teacher and Imam Khomeini's first formal teacher in gnosis and ethics[134]. The box below tells how Akhund Hamadani was himself trained.

Akhund Hamadani and the teachers of Tabataba'i's line were scholars, several of them jurists. Of the many Sufi orders, Tabataba'i grants that two or three are Shia[135]. His own line belonged to none of them: "we belong to none of these orders and follow the directions of the late Akhund, who had nothing to do with these orders"[136].

Tabataba'i still gives his line the names the orders use. He calls it "the chain of my preceptors"[137]. In *Kernel of the Kernels* he uses the word the Sheikh says Shia lack: "our tariqah is that of the marhum Akhund which does not end in any of these silsilahs"[138]. Set beside the Sheikh's point, the words name a line of teachers here, not a chain of authority beside the Imams.

These teachers taught the road this book describes, which runs to God through the self. Akhund Hamadani taught concentration on the self, and all his disciples followed "the method of gnosis (ma'rifah) of the soul, which is essential to the gnosis of the Lord"[139]. Qadi taught the same way. He asked a

[131] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 106.

[132] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 8.

[133] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 106; ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 89.

[134] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 106; Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 8.

[135] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 87–88.

[136] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 105.

[137] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 106.

[138] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 88.

[139] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 87.

traveller to set a time each day or night to attend to the self, "for half an hour or a little more"[140]. The guide the last section described, standing under the Imams and in no order, is therefore one Shia can name in recent generations.

STORY: THE WEAVER AT THE JUDGE'S DOOR

More than a hundred years before ʿAllama Tabataba'i told this story, Sayyid ʿAli Shushtari was a leading scholar and judge in the city of Shushtar. One day a weaver knocked at his door and told him that a ruling he had given on a property was wrong. The property belonged to an orphan, the weaver said, and its deed was buried in a certain place. Shushtari found the deed where the weaver had said, and found that the witnesses had lied. The weaver returned the next night and the night after with the same warning. On that third night he told Shushtari to sell his belongings, go to Najaf, and wait for him in the Wadi al-Salam after six months. Shushtari went, followed the weaver's instructions, and "reached a position too high to be described". In Najaf he attended Shaykh Murtada Ansari's lectures on jurisprudence and took over Ansari's teaching when Ansari died. Mulla Husayn-Quli Hamadani, one of Ansari's pupils, had long attended Shushtari's lessons in ethics and gnosis. In the last six months of his own life, Shushtari persuaded Hamadani to take up his way[141]. Tabataba'i traces his own line of teachers back to the weaver through Shushtari, and adds that "it is not known who that weaver was"[142].

How to test a guide

A line of true teachers does not make every teacher who claims a place in it true, so a guide must be tested. The question is whether he has walked the road himself. His learning cannot answer it. A teacher's writing or study does not show whether he has made the journey.

Wonders cannot answer it either. Tabataba'i's lectures list what cannot show that a person has reached the goal of the road (*wusul*): "extraordinary feats, knowledge of hidden things, of private thoughts of persons, passing over fire and water", and knowledge of the past and the future[143]. Such powers become possible early on the road, at "the beginning of spiritual vision"[144]. Yet

[140] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 107.

[141] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 105–106; ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 88–89.

[142] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 106.

[143] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 81.

[144] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 101.

"there is a very great distance between this point and the frontiers of wusul and perfection"[145]. A wonder may come from someone who sees what others do not, but it does not make him a friend of God (*wali*): such feats are "not a sign of anybody's being a favorite of Allah"[146].

Where wonders prove nothing, the law gives a firm test. Najm al-Din Kubra, the master of one of the Sufi orders, gave a rule for the road that applies here. Someone may be seen flying in the air or walking on the sea, but if they have abandoned "even one injunction of God", then "you should know that they are liars". Their wonders may be real, but their claim to know God is false.

Keeping the law rules a false guide out, but only time shows how far a true one has travelled. In Tabataba'i's lectures, the general teacher "is not recognized except through company and being with him in public and private"[147]. A traveller must watch him closely "for a considerable time"[148], as anyone comes to know a person, by living alongside him. One of Akhund Hamadani's pupils, whose story is in the box below, lived alongside his teacher for fourteen years.

> ◈ **WHO'S WHO: MIRZA JAWAD MALIKI TABRIZI**
>
> Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, "The most distinguished jurisprudent and perfect mystic" in his biographer's words, studied jurisprudence in Najaf under the great jurists of his day. There he came to know Akhund Mulla Husayn-Quli Hamadani, and he spent fourteen years with him, learning ethics and mysticism. He became a guide in his turn: the jurist Shaykh Muhammad Husayn Isfahani, himself an authority in learning and deeds, wrote asking for his instructions in ethics and mysticism. Maliki Tabrizi later settled in Qum, where he taught jurisprudence and ethics and wrote[149]. He died in 1925, and three years later his ethics class was resumed by Mirza Muhammad ʿAli Shahabadi, the teacher of Imam Khomeini. When Shahabadi left for Tehran in 1936, he gave the class to Imam Khomeini[150].

Not every traveller can keep long company with a teacher before trusting him, and there is a test for that case too. Where it is hard to inquire into a teacher's

[145] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 81.
[146] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 101.
[147] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 81.
[148] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 101.
[149] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 8.
[150] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 8.

state, the traveller should trust in God and weigh whatever the teacher says or prescribes "in the light of the Book of God and the Sunnah of the Messenger of Allah and the practice of the Immaculate Imams"[151]. Only what agrees with them is put into practice[152].

Care is needed either way, because the road has many pretenders, who put their wares on display with claims to unveiling and inner sight[153]. Imam Khomeini names what they do. Those who style themselves guides of God's creatures and leaders of mystic orders "have distracted the attention of the creatures of God from Him, attracting them towards themselves"[154]. 'Irfan is sought for God alone, so the test of a guide is whether he turns people towards God or towards himself.

The simplest form of the test comes in a saying of the Prophet 'Isa (as). It is recorded in *Lantern of the Path*, the book attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (as). They asked 'Isa with whom they should sit.

> *With one the sight of whom reminds you of Allah, ... and whose speech increases you in knowledge, and whose actions make you desire the next world.*[155]
>
> Lantern of the Path

'Isa's three marks all ask where a person's company turns us: towards Allah, towards knowledge, and towards the next world. They are marks a traveller can watch for over time, in the company he keeps.

Finding a guide therefore helps the traveller, as long as the guide is tested. A true guide has walked the road himself and walks beside the traveller under the Imams (as), never in their place. A guide's wonders prove nothing, and one who breaks the law is ruled out. Long company shows how far he has travelled, and the direction he turns people shows whether he is true.

Once a guide is found, what does the road itself look like?

[151] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 83.
[152] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 102.
[153] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 83.
[154] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 102.
[155] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari'a), p. 13.

➤ TRY THIS

This week, notice the people whose company you keep: at the mosque, at a majlis, at work, and at home. Of each, ask the three questions in ‘Isa’s answer. Does the sight of them remind you of Allah? Does their speech increase you in knowledge? Do their actions make you desire the next world[156]? Where you find someone of whom all three are true, seek out their company.

[156] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari‘a), p. 13.